POLITE COMPANY

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Written by

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[NOTE: For consistency, the characters are identified throughout this screenplay as KELLY and MARTIN. In dialogue, other characters may refer to them by their birth names, KEVIN and MOIRA, respectively.

Duck Hunt, *The Legend of Zelda: Breath of the Wild*, and *Super Metroid* may be substituted with ersatz equivalents.

Ed Wood and *The Silence of the Lambs* must be referenced by name, but no footage from either film is required. Any accompanying audio, including the song "Goodbye Horses," may be substituted with a sound-alike.]

FADE IN:

INT. LONDON TRAIN — DAY

KELLY (43), a trans woman in "boy mode" -- khakis, black polo, backpack. Masculine features. Something colourful and floral peeks out beneath the polo.

A passenger reads a tabloid: "TRANS IDEOLOGY GONE MAD."

Six young lads enter. Trainer brands. Confidence. Volume. Probably harmless. Possibly not.

Kelly buttons her polo higher, hiding the colour.

INT. KINGS CROSS PLATFORM — DAY — CONTINUOUS

She alights onto the platform.

A young woman (20s) is engulfed in a hug from her parents.

EXUBERANT MOTHER
There she is!

Mother and daughter squeal in unison. Dad beams.

Kelly watches. Something tightens behind her eyes.

She's jostled by a man rolling large luggage.

LARGE LUGGAGE MAN
Oh, sorry.

Kelly blinks, keeps walking.

INT./EXT. KINGS CROSS CONCOURSE - DAY - MOMENTS LATER

She passes "Wizard Wonders," an ersatz Harry Potter shop. Flips it off without looking.

She emerges from the crowded station. Christmas lights hang above Euston Road. Double-deckers crawl through traffic.

She puts in headphones and starts north.

MOBILE PHONE (V.O.)
You have -- three -- new messages. Message one.

MARTIN (V.O.)
Hey, sis, I'm calling to check on you after that whole... thing... at Thanksgiving. Maybe come spend Christmas with Greta and me? Dad says they've been trying to reach you. Call me.

MOBILE PHONE (V.O.)
Message two.

MEGAN (V.O.)
Hey, Toots, hear you're safe and back in London. Met a guy through work. He's my age. He's nice, he's kind, he's charming. Okay, he's a priest. But I can work with that. Better than Greg, anyway. Your mom's not taking things well. Call her if you can. Have fun in London, kiddo. Knock 'em dead.

MOBILE PHONE (V.O.)
Message three.

COLLEEN (V.O.)
Hey, Kelly. This is your mom. I just wanted to--

Kelly stops. Sighs, cuts the message off.

INSERT: Phone Screen

A prompt: "Delete Message" or "Remind Me Later."

Her finger hovers over "Delete." Then hits: "Remind Me." She keeps walking.

EXT. KING OF STARS PUB - DAY

A sign: "Stand Up Tonight."

Slightly scruffy. The kind of room good comics play and great comics graduate from.

INT. KING OF STARS - GREEN ROOM - DAY

A calendar on the wall. DECEMBER 2022.

Kelly removes her shirt and trousers — revealing a FLORAL DRESS underneath. She stuffs them into her backpack, pulls out a makeup bag.

KELLY
Right. Moisturiser, primer... foundation...?
(beat)
No, that's not right. Ah, fuzznuggets.

She finds a notepad in the backpack, checks it. Starts over.

A KNOCK at the door. KIERAN (70s, Scot, theatrical), leans against the frame, frowning.

KIERAN
I saw the new material you sent over.

KELLY
Hey Kieran. Yeah, what do you think?

KIERAN
Forget that. Kelly... *Are you alright?*

Kelly lowers the makeup sponge.

KIERAN (cont'd)
I mean, I'm a fan of dark comedy, but *Jesus Christ*, this isn't material, it's an open wound.

KELLY
Exactly. It won't heal if I keep it in. I need to work through what happened.

KIERAN
Kelly...

KELLY
Kieran. I have two options: I can laugh... or I can scream.

Kieran hesitates. A reluctant nod.

KIERAN
Have you tried drinking? That's a third option.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

KIERAN
And now, a special treat for you tonight. One of my favourite comedians, please give a warm welcome to Kelly O'Connell!

Kelly takes the stage. Keiran hands over the mic with a flourish.

She grabs the mic, wraps the cord around her wrist, places the stand behind her. Easy. Practised.

Her smile--genuine.

KELLY
Alright, let's just get this out of the way.
(gesture to self)
Yes. I am... American.
(beat, laughs)
Leave the questions for after the show. But the genitals are off limits. Asking a trans woman about her genitals is like asking the Queen about... her genitals. That's between her and the Jubilee Vajazzler.

Laughter, then Kelly pauses before continuing.

KELLY (cont'd)
I came out to my parents a couple of weeks ago. The pain is still fresh.
(shrugging)
Which means it's officially stand-up material.

Relieved laughter.

KELLY (cont'd)
Eight months ago, my pronouns suddenly became "she" and "her." Naturally, my *adjectives* became "overwhelmed" and "bewildered." I had to throw my own gender reveal party. It wrapped up at ten because all my friends are in our forties. We had acid reflux. The reveal was when we opened up the Pepto Bismol.

She acts out opening the bottle.

KELLY (cont'd)
Pink! Congratulations. It's a bouncing baby ulcer!
(beat, laughs)
It took me forty-three years to figure myself out. Why so long? Well to answer that...

EXT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - 1992 - DAY

North Carolina summer-bright. Wide porch, neat lawn. Two cars. A "ROSS PEROT FOR PRESIDENT" sign. RORY (40s) adjusts American and POW/MIA flags.

INT. KELLY'S BEDROOM — DAY

Comedy posters. Books on computers, philosophy and Irish myth. Disassembled electronics. A small CRT hooked to an NES.

Kelly (13) plays *Duck Hunt*. Drops one duck. Misses the next. Sighs.

In the CRT: the game -- and Kelly's reflection, staring back.

Next round. Kelly puts the toy Zapper in her mouth.

Click. (8-bit bang). Click. (8-bit bang). Click. (8-bit bang).

The pixelated dog laughs.

She powers everything off. Falls onto the bed. Stares at the ceiling.

COLLEEN (O.S.)
Kevin, if you're not dressed yet, get dressed. You've got CCD in a half hour, and if you show up late, the nuns will make you wear a wimple.

Kelly reacts with confusion.

INT. COLLEEN'S CAR - DAY

Kelly rides shotgun. MARTIN ("Moira", 10), slumps in back. COLLEEN (50s) drives, crucifix over conservative hausfrau attire.

KELLY
Why a wimple?

COLLEEN
Being late is a bad habit. A wimple is a good habit. Ba-dum-tish!

Colleen smiles sweetly. Kelly and Martin groan as they pull up to church.

EXT. CHURCH - DAY - CONTINUOUS

Kelly gets out. Colleen calls after her:

COLLEEN
Kevin?

Kevin turns back.

KELLY
Yeah, Mom?

Colleen's smile can't hide her worry.

COLLEEN
Just... try not to give the nuns a hard time, okay? I don't want to get a phone call and have to pick you up early again.

Kelly hangs her head.

KELLY
Okay.

EXT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - DAY

Colleen's car pulls into the driveway.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - DAY

Martin heads in. Colleen drops purse and keys. The answering machine blinks.

She sighs, presses PLAY.

SISTER MARY SARAH (V.O.)
Hello, Mrs. O'Connell? This is Sister Mary Sarah. There was another incident with Kevin. Can you come pick him up?

Colleen retrieves purse and keys.

INT. KELLY'S ROOM - DAY

Martin sneaks in, opens Kelly's underwear drawer. Finds an unopened package. Looks around, grabs it.

COLLEEN (O.S.)
(calling)
Moira! Come back, we need to go and pick up your brother.

Martin is startled, gasps, then relieved.

MARTIN
(calling)
Coming, Mom!
(MORE)

MARTIN (cont'd)
(to self)
That's gotta be a new record.

INT. MOTHER SUPERIOR'S OFFICE - DAY

Kelly sits in MOTHER SUPERIOR'S office. Martin meanders as an exasperated Colleen sits beside Kelly.

COLLEEN
What was it this time?

KELLY
I told them that I wasn't going to do confirmation.

COLLEEN
Kevin, the whole point of CCD is to get you ready for confirmation.

KELLY
Noted, but I *can't* do confirmation. I don't believe in God.

In the background, Mother Superior works at her desk.

COLLEEN
Kevin...

KELLY
I don't *not* believe in God. I just... don't feel it. I can't just have faith. Doesn't feel like there's a God. Grannie died. Kids at school hate me. I'm failing Lions-Quest.

COLLEEN
Lions-Quest?

KELLY
It's a self-esteem class. They literally grade how wrong I feel. How would you feel... if you were being *graded* on how you *feel?* And then told you were *failing?*

Martin is sneaking up on Mother Superior in the background, trying to peek at Mother Superior's hair under her wimple.

COLLEEN
Can't you just... go along with it for now?

KELLY
Confirmation is swearing to God I believe.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
If there's no God, then it's just theatre. If there *is* a God, and I say I believe when I *don't?* It's perjury. Damned if I do and damned if I don't. (sigh) Catechism-22.

Colleen rubs her temple. Stress headache.

COLLEEN
You rehearsed that, didn't you?

Kelly almost smirks.

KELLY
A little.

COLLEEN
Kevin, I don't need you to become St. Augustine. I just need you to stop getting thrown out of CCD.

KELLY
I know, I know... I'm too (air quotes) "disruptive."

COLLEEN
Disruptive? Back in my day, the nuns would have made you drink *hemlock*.

MOTHER SUPERIOR
Whoa!
(beat)
That hasn't been true since Vatican II!

Mother Superior almost catches Martin in the act, but he pulls his hand away just in time.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

KELLY
I was what they called a 'gifted kid.' Which primarily meant adults became visibly annoyed when I was right.
(beat)
My parents knew I was depressed. They just figured I was too *smart* to be *happy*.
(act-out)
"Our son's not queer! He's a *philosopher!*"

Laughter. Beat.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - DINING ROOM TABLE - DAY

Kelly and Martin play Monopoly.

KELLY (STAND-UP) (O.S.)
Both Martin and I were "gifted" but we were completely different kinds of gifted.

Kelly (thimble) passes GO, takes $200, checks a dot-matrix printout.

INSERT: The dot-matrix paper. Landing probabilities and 1—5 star investment ratings for every property.

KELLY (STAND-UP) (O.S.) (cont'd)
I was the smart one.

Kelly buys third houses for New York and St. James. The oranges.

Martin (cannon) rolls: St. James. Kelly holds out her hand.

POV: UNDER THE TABLE

Monopoly money is Blu-Tacked beneath the table.

KELLY (STAND-UP) (O.S.) (cont'd)
Martin... was the *clever* one.

Martin cheerfully pays Kelly with his right hand while sneaking a $500 bill with his left.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

KELLY (STAND-UP) (O.S.)
Martin hid Monopoly money so well my parents are still finding bills hidden around the house to this day.
(laughter, beat)
Course, it didn't help being smart. Not even at school. I mean, you'd think it'd be the one place, right?

SFX: (PRE-LAP) A school bell.

INT. HIGH SCHOOL LUNCH-ROOM - 1994 - DAY

Kelly (15) whispers with a FRIEND (15). Behind her is a table full of girls. REBECCA (16), Star of David pendant, passes by, with her lunch tray.

REBECCA
Hey, Kevin.

Kelly startles -- nearly chokes on school-issued milk. Rebecca snorts, sits with the girls behind Kelly.

FRIEND
You really have a thing for her, don't you?

KELLY
I'll say. I'd cut both my balls off just to see her smile.

The friend blinks at Kelly.

FRIEND
Kevin?
(drawn out)
Why is that your *plan*... "*A?*"

KELLY
You think I should start with flowers?

FRIEND
You know Rebecca's lesbian, right?

KELLY
No, she's Jewish.

Rebecca overhears, fighting a laugh.

Kelly psychs herself up.

KELLY (cont'd)
Right. Right. I'm doing this.

Kelly turns to Rebecca.

KELLY (cont'd)
Hey, uh, Rebecca?

Rebecca turns, trying to keep from laughing, still.

KELLY (cont'd)
I was wondering if you would be interested in maybe seeing a movie. You know. If you're free.

A beat, Rebecca shrugs. Dead silence.

KELLY (cont'd)
I mean, it doesn't *have* to be a movie. It could be--

Rebecca mercifully stops the spiral.

REBECCA
Kevin. You're a good friend, and a sweet guy, but us dating?
(MORE)

REBECCA (cont'd)
That would be a terrible idea. You're not my type.

KELLY
What-- what is your type?

REBECCA
Women.

A beat, Rebecca shrugs. Dead silence.

KELLY
Hey. That's my type too! We have *so much* in common.

Rebecca thinks, narrows her eyes.

REBECCA
Tell you what. We can go... as *friends*.

KELLY
Okay!

REBECCA
This will end badly. You know that, right?

KELLY
I mean, what doesn't?

EXT. MOVIE THEATRE - NIGHT

It's a small movie theatre. The Marquee says: "PULP FICTION", "THE SHAWSHANK REDEMPTION," "ED WOOD."

The two are sitting on a bench outside, talking.

REBECCA
Kevin? You're really sweet. But I mostly agreed to this because Dad thinks I only like girls because I haven't tried dating guys. This... will keep him off my back for a while.

Kelly nods. She doesn't like it, but she understands perfectly.

KELLY
I know the feeling.

REBECCA
You do?

KELLY
Yeah. Mom's the same about Catholicism. Thinks faith might make me less depressed. Maybe I can get her off my back if I say you got me interested in converting.

REBECCA
To Judaism?

KELLY
Unless there's a way to convert to lesbianism.

Rebecca snort-laughs.

REBECCA
Mom thinks that it's a phase. That I'll grow out of it in college. Like she did.

She smiles at Kelly.

REBECCA (cont'd)
Honestly? You're going to be a really good boyfriend to someone someday.

Kelly sadly smiles.

KELLY
Just not today.

REBECCA
C'mon. Movie's about to start.

INT. MOVIE THEATRE - DAY

Rebecca and Kelly share a popcorn. *Ed Wood* plays.

MOVIE-WEISS (O.S.)
Well screw you! (hangs up phone) Hi, can I help ya?

MOVIE-ED-WOOD (O.S.)
Yes, I'm Ed Wood. I'm here about directing the Christine Jorgensen picture.

Kelly raises an eyebrow.

INT. SCHOOL LIBRARY - DAY

CLOSE ON: a card catalogue entry:

JORGENSEN, CHRISTINE

See:
TRANSSEXUALISM
See also:
SEX REASSIGNMENT
SEXUAL PERVERSIONS

Kelly flips through another drawer.

CLOSE ON: another card catalogue.

TRANSSEXUALISM
306.768

Bullough, Vern.
Sexual Variance in Society and History

Green, Richard.
The "Sissy Boy Syndrome"

Various periodicals

Kelly sits with a stack of books. Opens one.

Reads. Turns a page.

Reads. Another page.

Stops. Looks up.

The library windows have gone dark.

INT. CLASSROOM - DAY

A sombre classroom. Kelly sits front row, Rebecca behind her.

A GIRL sits beside Rebecca, smiles. Rebecca blushes, tucks her hair behind her ear.

Kelly doesn't notice, absorbed in her notebook:

INSERT: Notebook: "Born George Jorgensen?" "Denmark?" "1952" "Permanent?" "Other people?"

The TEACHER enters, shaken.

TEACHER
Hello everyone. I, uh, heard the news. I know a lot of you were fans of Kurt Cobain from Nirvana.

A few kids look down. Kelly looks up briefly, then goes to her notebook, only half paying attention.

TEACHER (cont'd)
I wanted to check in. When something like this happens, it can really affect people.

Kelly continues to write, tongue out in concentration.

TEACHER (O.S.)
Has anyone here ever thought about suicide?

Without looking up, Kelly matter-of-factly raises her hand.

The room goes silent.

TEACHER
Kevin?

Kelly looks up. No other hands. Everyone is staring.

TEACHER (cont'd)
You've been thinking about--

KELLY
Doesn't everybody?

She turns around to look at the class.

Rebecca shakes her head, slowly.

Kelly finally notices everyone staring. The awkwardness somehow gets worse.

Kelly hangs her head, but keeps her hand up.

KELLY (cont'd)
Ah beans.

INT. SCHOOL HALLWAY - DAY

Kelly is going to her locker. She opens it.

POV: FROM INSIDE THE LOCKER:

A crude noose made of clothesline hangs from the hooks on top. Kelly immediately shuts the locker.

She freezes.

A BULLY and his entourage taunt her as they pass.

BULLY
Hey, Buckshot.

Kelly's face falls. The bully walks off laughing. Kelly heads the other way.

INT. SCHOOL HALLWAY - DAY - LATER

The hallway is empty. Kelly drags a bin to her locker, checks she's alone, opens it and throws the noose away.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - DAY

Colleen and Rory are watching TV.

Kelly drops her backpack heavily on the ground, then collapses onto the couch.

COLLEEN
Rough day, kiddo?

KELLY
Aren't they all? The kids have started calling me "buckshot." Someone broke into my locker and left a noose there.

COLLEEN
What?

RORY
Did you tell anyone at school? A teacher?

KELLY
Of course not. What's a teacher going to do? Best case, nothing happens. Worst case, they think I put it in there myself.

RORY
Why would they think you made a death threat to *yourself?*

KELLY
Turns out, most kids don't think about death as often as I do. Or at all.

Colleen and Rory have no answer.

COLLEEN
Maybe it's just a prank. They didn't realise how much it would hurt. You know. Kids will be kids.

Kelly curls up into the fetal position.

RORY
Don't worry about it. They want to see you react. Don't, and they'll get bored. Just act normal for a while. Trust me. It'll blow over.

Rory and Colleen go back to watching TV. Kelly just stays curled up on the couch.

Kelly quietly sobs into the sofa. Colleen notices, nudges Rory's attention toward her.

RORY (cont'd)
Uh, Kevin, you know, uh, how would you feel if we got you to talk with a psychologist for a bit?

KELLY
(confused)
Like Dr. Ruth?

COLLEEN
(taken aback)
No. More like *Frasier*. But, for kids.

Kelly shrugs.

INT. PSYCHOLOGIST OFFICE - DAY

Kelly sits on a couch. DR. HOLLADAY, 40s, takes notes.

KELLY
I don’t know why I'm miserable. It's like there's something missing.
(beat)
Maybe it’s love. But that feels like... the wrong answer to the wrong question.

HOLLADAY
I don't know. It works for a lot of people. Why do you mention it?

Kelly blushes, clutching a pillow to her chest.

KELLY
I've got a little crush. Rebecca.

Holladay writes.

KELLY (cont'd)
She’s just so pretty. Knows exactly who she is. Smart.

HOLLADAY
Sounds like a real crush.

KELLY
Yeah. I hate it. Unrequited.

INSERT -- NOTEPAD: "Normal adolescent crush" "Advanced vocabulary"

KELLY (cont'd)
It'll never work. She's a lesbian. (sigh) Doctor Holladay... do you ever wonder what it's like to be a lesbian?

Holladay looks up.

HOLLADAY
No.
(beat)
Do you?

KELLY
I mean, being a lesbian... it seems like... fun?
(beat)
Girls seem... comfortable. With each other. They hug a lot. Nobody thinks it's weird.
(beat)
I don’t know why, but... I think I’d rather be... like them?

Holladay studies her.

HOLLADAY
Well, it's not like you can.

Kelly rubs her temples.

KELLY
I was reading about this woman... Christine Jorgensen...

Holladay drops his pen. Kelly freezes. He retrieves it, fumbling:

HOLLADAY
(slowly)
Christine Jorgensen?

KELLY
Yeah.

HOLLADAY
Let me stop you there. Christine Jorgensen was a very unusual case. Extraordinarily uncommon. That's not something you experiment with. You'd have to be absolutely certain. It isn't reversible.
(beat)
It's easier to dig a hole than to build a pole.

Kelly stares past him.

KELLY
Oh.

HOLLADAY
Besides, from what you've said about Rebecca, you certainly don't sound *gay*.

Kelly shrugs, looking down.

KELLY
Yeah. Nobody wants that.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

Adult Kelly continues.

KELLY
I didn't show any of the (air quotes) "classic" signs. My brother, on the other hand. Textbook. Came out as a lesbian at twelve. Wore boys' clothes. Stole my boxer shorts. And no -- I didn't steal his panties. They wouldn't have fit. I, uh... I checked.

INT. COLLEGE DORM ROOM - DAY

SUPER: AUGUST 2002

A bare dorm room. Pink walls. Bunk bed. Metal desk.

Martin (18), butch, enters with supplies and psychology textbooks. Kelly (22) follows, lugging a CRT monitor.

Martin points to the desk. Kelly sets it down.

INT. COLLEGE DORM ROOM - DAY - LATER

Kelly crouches under the desk, swapping a phone line for Ethernet.

KELLY
Knew it. This is, like, 90% of what I do at the shop. Boot it up?

Martin powers it up.

MARTIN
Neat. Thanks.

Martin slumps onto the bed. Kelly notices.

KELLY
Moira, hey--what’s up?

Martin shrugs. Kelly sits beside him.

MARTIN
I'm scared. I didn't think I would be.

KELLY
Living in a women's dorm. As a lesbian. Must be *hell*.

Martin shuts the door, returns tense.

MARTIN
Kevin... I hate being a girl.
(beat)
I kinda want to... get rid of my breasts. Be a guy. Like that Hilary Swank movie.

Kelly freezes.

KELLY
(softly)
Can I have 'em?

MARTIN
Kevin...

KELLY
They seem fun.

Martin glares. Kelly softens.

KELLY (cont'd)
Look, Moira... I'm on your side.

She takes Martin's hand.

MARTIN
You don't get it.

KELLY
I said I'm on your side. I didn't say I'd be *good* at it.

Martin rests his head on Kelly's shoulder.

MARTIN
Not a word to Mom and Dad.

KELLY
Alright. Your call, Moira.

Martin shrugs.

MARTIN
Maybe if I showed them the movie.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Kelly enters. Rory and Colleen watch TV, nod hello.

KELLY
Moira's all moved in. What's on?

COLLEEN
Silence of the Lambs.

MUSIC CUE: "Goodbye Horses" from *Silence of the Lambs*.

Kelly flops onto the couch--

TV-BUFFALO-BILL (O.S.)
Would you [bleep] me--?

Kelly turns.

The rest of the line continues under:

TV-BUFFALO-BILL (O.S.) (cont'd)
--I'd [bleep] me. I'd [bleep] me hard.

Kelly goes still.

COLLEEN
It's just not the same when it's on basic cable.

Kelly sinks down into the couch.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

KELLY
Trans men got Brandon Teena. I got Buffalo Bill. That movie won five Oscars... then crawled into my childhood and pissed on the furniture.
(beat)
My brother came out as a trans man the next year. I came out to myself... twenty years later.
(beat)
Now when my brother calls me "a big dummy," he has objective proof.

MONTAGE:

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY KITCHEN - DAY

SUPER: "2003"

An acceptance letter to Central Texas University on the table. Colleen cries; Kelly consoles her.

COLLEEN
Texas is a long way to go for another degree.

KELLY
That’s sort of the point. Maybe a change of scenery is what I need to be happy.

EXT. TEXAS GRADUATION CEREMONY - DAY

SUPER: "2005"

Kelly, exhausted in graduation robes. Caps fly. Graduates cheer. Kelly opens a notebook: COMPARATIVE POLITICS — BOOK PROPOSAL.

KELLY
(to self)
Maybe a big project...

QUICK CUTS:

- EXT. SYDNEY OPERA HOUSE - DAY

SUPER: "2008"

Kelly smiles for a tourist's camera. FLASH. The smile disappears.

- EXT. EIFFEL TOWER - DAY

SUPER: "2010"

Friends laugh together. Kelly laughs half a second late.

- EXT. BRANDENBURG GATE - DAY

SUPER: "2012"

Kelly takes a selfie, studies it, deletes it.

INT. TX COUNTY DEMOCRATIC PARTY MEETING - DAY

SUPER: "2014"

A sparse crowd beneath a "CEDAR PARK COUNTY DEMOCRATIC PARTY" banner. Kelly wears a suit and tie.

KELLY
(to self)
Maybe helping people...

PHOTO FLASH --

The photo becomes a campaign poster: KEVIN O'CONNELL — GEEK FOR TX HOUSE.

INT. TEXAS BAR (ELECTION NIGHT) - NIGHT

PULL BACK: Election Night. Kelly and the Democrats watch the returns in a bar. It is *not* going well.

KELLY
(to self)
Maybe if I learn to code...

INT. AMERICAN TECH COMPANY OFFICE - DAY

SUPER: "2018"

Kelly hands her BOSS a resignation letter.

BOSS
Kevin, you're *quitting?*

KELLY
Got a job offer in England.
Figured with Trump in charge,
now's a good time to get out.

BOSS
But I thought things were going well.

KELLY
They were.

The boss waits.

KELLY (cont'd)
I don't think that's the same as
being happy.

END MONTAGE.

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - BEDROOM - DAWN

SUPER: "2022"

Kelly sleeps on a mail-order foam mattress, fitted sheet half-off. Her pillow has no case.

She grinds her teeth in her sleep.

Piles of clothing. None obviously the clean one. An unopened IKEA wardrobe box leans against the wall.

A wall of photos, blu-tacked in loose constellations.

Faces age from image to image. Kelly's smile never quite reaches her eyes. Martin's grows brighter with each passing year.

PHOTOS & DOCUMENTS:

- Martin (24) with GRETA (24, Norwegian). Next: their Norwegian elopement.

- Kelly and Martin in Norway beneath a shop sign: "BROTHERS"

- Kelly in a London park, masked friends waving from a distance. Double-decker, Georgian terraces behind.

A cluttered computer desk. Laptop, notes, books: "JavaScript: The Good Parts," "Autism Diagnosis in Adulthood," "Dealing with Chronic Depression," and "X-Men: God Loves, Man Kills."

The alarm clock BEEP BEEP BEEPs. Kelly clutches the sheets tighter. Tries burying her head in her pillow.

She hits snooze. Then immediately falls back down into bed.

A second alarm ACROSS THE ROOM joins in.

Kelly groans like a mummy's curse. Ancient. Resentful.

INT. OPEN PLAN OFFICE - DAY

Kelly sits between engineers SAMANTHA and ELLIE.

Ellie's laptop bristles with feminist stickers: ABOLISH THE PAY GAP. WOMEN IN CODE. SMASH THE PATRIARCHY.

ELLIE
You should come to the meetup, Sam. We're doing intro to Python.

SAMANTHA
Is there a fee?

ELLIE
Nah, but it's nice to order a drink or two from the venue.

KELLY
I'd be down to learn Python. Where's the meetup?

ELLIE
Ah, no, Kevin, sorry. It's the monthly Women Who Code meetup.

Kelly sighs.

KELLY
Oh.

SAMANTHA
Otherwise, we'd invite you in a heartbeat.

ELLIE
When the revolution comes, you will be one of the men we spare from the guillotines.

KELLY
You're going to chop men's heads off?

ELLIE
No, just their balls.

KELLY
Oh, that's not so bad then.

SAMANTHA
It's just that... women need a space, you know? A place where we don't have to worry about...

KELLY
No, I get it. Guy like me walks into a room, you have to wonder: threat? Perv? I think about what it's like to be a woman a lot.

Ellie nods.

ELLIE
It's not fun.

SAMANTHA
(sotto)
Parts of it are fun.

KELLY
Yeah, women absolutely have it harder than men. Especially in tech.

ELLIE
Damn straight.

KELLY
But... okay. Stop me if this is stupid or sexist--

ELLIE
Ah, bup bup bup. Kevin, close your eyes.

Kelly does. Ellie takes a candy bar wrapper off the desk and CRINKLES it near Kelly's ear.

ELLIE (cont'd)
Listen. That is the sound of thin ice, cracking.

Kelly opens her eyes.

ELLIE (cont'd)
You've been warned. Go ahead.

KELLY
Right. Well... feminism says there's no wrong way to be a woman.

SAMANTHA
Okay. Sure.

KELLY
But there absolutely is a wrong way to be a man. We're just... expected to do things. Even bad things, and if we don't, we're somehow wrong. I just think... maybe the way my brain works... it'd be easier for me to handle the problems women face than the problems I face as a man. Does that make sense?

Ellie and Samantha stare.

ELLIE
That's the saddest thing you've ever said to me.

SAMANTHA
Kevin, are you okay?

INT. OFFICE BREAK AREA - DAY

Kelly makes coffee. The Nespresso whirrs. Her boss, NIGEL, joins her.

NIGEL
Kevin. How are you doing?

KELLY
Hey, Nigel. Fine, I guess. And you?

NIGEL
Oh, no, this is a genuine inquiry. Not small talk.

KELLY
Oh. That's refreshing.

NIGEL
Not really. I, uh, Kevin, people are worried about you.

KELLY
That's... nice.

NIGEL
You haven't been yourself lately.

A beat.

KELLY
I don't think that's the problem.

NIGEL
Well, whatever it is, don't try to carry it alone. Okay?
(beat)
We have an employee assistance programme. Have you considered seeing a professional?

KELLY
A dominatrix?
(realizing)
You meant a *therapist*. Ah fluffernutter.

Nigel laughs.

NIGEL
Is that part of your stand-up act?

KELLY
It is now.

NIGEL
That's this Thursday?

KELLY
Yeah. Student showcase, so no guarantees it'll be good.

NIGEL
I'll be there if I can. Look, mental health is important to us. Take some time if you need it.

A beat.

NIGEL (cont'd)
After the product launch, obviously.

KELLY
I'll be sure to schedule my mental health around the deliverables.

NIGEL
Good man.

INT. OFF-WEST-END PUB - NIGHT

A HOST finishes his warm-up to supportive cheers.

HOST
Welcome to the stage: Kevin O'Connell!

Kelly waits nervously. She gulps, takes the stage.

She forces high energy:

KELLY
Are you feeling good tonight? Let me hear it!

The crowd cheers louder.

KELLY (cont'd)
I'm here to talk about depression.

Her shoulders slump. A deep sigh.

A laugh -- then the energy dips.

KELLY (cont'd)
Apparently it’s called dysthymia. Sounds like the name of an amusement park.
(beat)
There’s a hall of mirrors--but the mirrors are working fine. It's me that's the freak show.

Scattered laughter. Then silence. Someone coughs.

INT. OFF-WEST-END PUB - LATER

Comics cluster. Kelly sits alone. An AUDIENCE MEMBER approaches tentatively.

AUDIENCE MEMBER
Hey. I saw your set.

KELLY
Really? You thought it was funny?

AUDIENCE MEMBER
I thought... it was brave, you know.
(beat)
I mean--if you ever need to, like... talk to someone...

The audience member hands her a card. She flips it: "YOU ARE NOT ALONE." Samaritans number.

Kelly forces a smile.

KELLY
Thanks.

The audience member leaves.

Kelly opens her wallet. Inside: several identical cards.

She adds another.

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - BEDROOM - NIGHT

Kelly slumps into her office chair in a green “Kiss Me, I’m Vaccinated” shamrock shirt.

Tea down. She doom-scrolls, glassy-eyed.

A news article: Russia Invades Ukraine. She scrolls.

A YouTube video: Porch pirates get glitter bombed. She scrolls.

A *Real Life Comics* strip in her feed. She stops. She clicks.

Frame 1: a young man at a computer.

MATCH CUT -- Kelly at hers.

Frame 2: a social post.

KELLY
(reading)
If you think you're a cis guy but you've always dreamed of being a girl -- and the only thing stopping you is fear you'd be an "ugly" girl -- that's dysphoria. You're already a trans girl, babe.

The cartoon man frowns. Kelly frowns.

He stiffens. She stiffens.

He panics. She panics.

Kelly leans back, covers her face.

KELLY (cont'd)
(slowly)
Oh dip.

Silence.

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - BATHROOM - NIGHT

Kelly studies her reflection. Squints.

Touches her jawline. Fascination. Dread.

SMASH CUT:

Electrical tape pulls her cheeks tight. Glue tugs at her temples — crooked, too tight. Barely able to blink.

KELLY
Well... I don't know what I expected.

INT. KELLY'S FLAT — BEDROOM — NIGHT

Kelly lies on the bed.

She presses a pillow over her face.

EXT. KELLY'S FLAT - CONTINUOUS

A muffled scream.

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - LIVING AREA - DAY

Kelly paces nervously, phone in hand.

KELLY
Martin's been through this. Don't be overdramatic. But don't be underdramatic. This is... kind of a big thing. I'm not overwhelmed. I'm not underwhelmed, I am... appropriately whelmed.

INT. MARTIN'S HOME - DAY

MARTIN, now 39, respectable beard, warm sweater, reads in a cosy Scandinavian living room. Snow outside. Norwegian books on the shelves.

On the wall: family photos, many matching Kelly's. A diploma: B.A. Psychology — Moira O'Connell.

The phone RINGS. He reaches over and picks up.

INTERCUT
INT. KELLY'S FLAT &
INT. MARTIN'S FLAT - DAY

KELLY
Hey, Martin. It's Kevin... your brother.

MARTIN
(rolls eyes)
Yes, Kevin, I know who you are. How's London life? How's the stand-up going?

KELLY
It's going... listen, is this a good time for a big talk? Unless you're busy solving murders in the snow.

MARTIN
What?

KELLY
That's what Norwegians do on Netflix, right?

Martin groans.

MARTIN
You sound nervous. More than usual, I mean. Did something happen?

KELLY
Kinda? I think I might be an egg.

Martin slow-blinks, concerned, and heads to the bookcase.

MARTIN
You think... you might be an *egg*?

He scans psychology books.

KELLY
I only realized it yesterday. I mean, it makes sense. I've been talking to people on the internet, they say I'm an egg, that I talk like an egg and think like an egg and--

MARTIN
Kevin. Bro. Slow down.

KELLY
Right. Before I make any big decisions, I wanted to call you. Since you were an egg once.

Martin squints, dubiously.

MARTIN
I was an *egg*?

KELLY
Well... yeah.

MARTIN
When you say "egg"... what do you mean?

KELLY
You know... egg. I just realized... I might be transgender too.

Martin stills.

MARTIN
Okay. So *not a literal egg*.

From another shelf -- not psychology -- he pulls TRANSGENDER JOURNEYS.

He stops. Scowls.

MARTIN (cont'd)
Wait a second.
(beat)
Are you *stealing my bit?*

END INTERCUT.

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - LIVING AREA - LATER

Kelly cocoons in a duvet, tea in hand, Martin on her laptop.

MARTIN
Right... Okay... Yeah.

KELLY
So... what do I do?

MARTIN
I don't know, Kevin. This is... a lot.
(pause)
Don't... tell Mom and Dad right away. I don't know how they'd react.

KELLY
..."Here we go again?"

Martin sips coffee, thinking.

MARTIN
Are you *sure, sure?*

KELLY
No. How do I get sure-sure?

MARTIN
You could try hormone replacement therapy.

KELLY
Looked it up. The UK gender clinic wait is somewhere between four years and the heat death of the universe. If I join today, I might bequeath my place to my future granddaughter.

MARTIN
Maybe you could do grey-market?

KELLY
Is that safe?

MARTIN
I don’t know. But, some people do it. If it doesn't feel right, you can stop.

Kelly pulls the duvet tighter.

KELLY
But what if it *does?* Feel right, I mean.

MARTIN
Then maybe the depression lifts. More energy. Softer skin. You'll probably smell better. Bald spot could make a comeback.
(sincere)
But that's only in the worst case scenario.

INT. SHOPPING CENTER - DAY

SERIES OF SHOTS:

- Chemist. Kelly buys makeup under a clerk's scrutiny.

KELLY
Niece's birthday.

- Clothing store. Kelly holds the FLORAL DRESS to herself. Another shopper stares.

KELLY (cont'd)
Pantomime dame.

- Shoe store, Kelly wobbles in heels. A CURIOUS BOY watches.

KELLY (cont'd)
For reaching tall shelves.

CURIOUS BOY
(gasp!) That's brilliant.

Kelly smiles.

CURIOUS BOY (O.S.)
Mum, can I get heels?

Kelly's smile dies.

INT. OUTSIDE KELLY'S FLAT — DAY

A parcel waits at her door. Plain. Medical. Aggressively boring.

She checks both ways, grabs it, slips inside.

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - LIVING AREA - DAY

The box. Label: "HORMONAL SOLUTIONS LTD."

Inside: oestrogen patches. A box of finasteride.

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - BATHROOM - DAY

Kelly presses the patch to her hip.

INT. KING OF STARS PUB - STAGE - NIGHT

KELLY
And that was it. Like a nicotine patch for sugar, spice, and everything nice. At first, it didn't seem like much.
(beat)
But everyone around me could tell something was different. Like winning the lottery. I didn't tell anyone, but there were signs.

INT. OPEN PLAN OFFICE - DAY

Lively, Kelly plants a tiny trans pride flag and plastic flower in a mug marked "World's Okayest Engineer," boots up and codes.

Sam and Ellie return. Sam spots the mug.

SAMANTHA
Kevin! You got a plant! And a flag?

ELLIE
Oh, that's so cool! A trans pride flag! For your brother in Norway, right?

KELLY
Uh, yeah. Oh, by the way, I had a revelation last night.

SAMANTHA
What kind of revelation?

Kelly points eagerly at her screen.

KELLY
We're optimizing the wrong thing. The dashboard isn't slow because of rendering. We're fetching the same data over and over.

SAMANTHA
Wait. Every time a component mounts?

KELLY
Yep. Shared query cache. Deduplicated requests. See?

SAMANTHA
Oh, that's clever.

ELLIE
And that'll take a load off the backend.

KELLY
Exactly!

Nigel approaches with coffee.

NIGEL
Howdy ladies. And Kevin.

He notices the flag.

NIGEL (cont'd)
That's a cool flag! What is that, Belize?

SAMANTHA
It's a trans pride flag. To show support for his brother.

ELLIE
Seriously, Kevin, you're such a good guy.

Kelly smiles.

KELLY
Aw, I wouldn't say that...

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - LIVING AREA - DAY

Kelly lounges in the FLORAL DRESS and makeup.

She snaps a selfie. Sends it: “Worst Case Scenario <grin emoji>”

The phone rings. Kelly picks up.

MARTIN (V.O.)
So, this is real?

KELLY
I think it is.

MARTIN (V.O.)
My condolences.

Kelly laughs. Martin does not.

MARTIN (V.O.) (cont'd)
Greta and I are coming over. You're gonna need support for this.

KELLY
Only if you promise to see my stand-up act when you're here.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE (FIRST PERFORMANCE) - DAY

Martin and Greta are in the audience. Greta records on her phone.

KIERAN
Our next act is a special occasion. She's performing for the first time... as Kelly.
(beat)
So tonight, I want you to be part of Kelly's new family.

Martin claps too early. Realizes. Keeps clapping anyway. A few people join. Then the room fills with applause.

KIERAN (cont'd)
Ladies, gentlemen--everyone. Kelly O’Connell!

Kelly steps onstage in the FLORAL DRESS. Kieran offers a fist bump.

KIERAN (cont'd)
(low)
These are your people.

Applause carries as she reaches the mic.

INT. KING OF STARS PUB UPSTAIRS - DAY

Kelly, Martin, Greta, Kieran and other comics share pints on the patio, laughing.

Kelly is the happiest we've ever seen her.

Martin snaps a candid photo of Kelly mid-laugh -- pure joy.

KELLY (PRE-LAP)
God, if only the story ended there.

INT. KING OF STARS PUB (STAGE) - NIGHT

Kelly is still on stage, in the present day (Dec. 2022). She gives the audience a knowing look.

KELLY
Trans stories should have happy endings, don't you think?

Kelly slowly shakes her head for comic effect.

She looks over to Kieran in the wings, and nods to him.

KELLY (cont'd)
So, Kieran's going to do a bit of housekeeping, and we'll have a quick break so you can go and get drinks, use the loo, change your gender, whatever strikes your fancy, and I'll be back in about ten minutes.

Kieran walks onstage, Kelly hands the mic to him.

As Kelly leaves for backstage, Kieran addresses the crowd.

KIERAN
So, just a reminder, be kind and tip your waitstaff, the kitchen is closes at half-past, and if you're going to snort cocaine off the toilet seats, remember to wipe it down before *and* after.

We follow Kelly as she heads backstage.

INT. KING OF STARS (BACKSTAGE) - NIGHT

Kelly takes out her cellphone, dials. One ring. Two.

MARTIN (V.O.)
Kelly? You okay?

KELLY
Yeah. (hesitates) Yeah. Look, I can't talk long, I'm just about to do the second half of my set, but, about Christmas. I think I may take you up on that. But weren't you planning a Disney trip with Greta for Christmas?

MARTIN
We've decided to do it for January instead. Cheaper flights.

KELLY
Makes sense. (pause) Do you think Greta's family would be fine with a trans woman at Christmas dinner?

MARTIN
Yes.

KELLY
Because it's one thing for you to--

MARTIN
Kelly, I get it. Yes, they'll be fine. It won't be like Thanksgiving.

Kelly peeks from backstage to the audience. We see people milling about. To the side, Kieran is in pleasant conversation with ASH (20s, gender-nonconforming).

Ash looks glum. Kieran rubs their back.

KELLY
Funny thing, I'm just about to tell that story on stage.

MARTIN
Uh, that's not... I'd have thought that...

Kelly sighs. Tight face. Determination and a little fear.

KELLY
I know. I know. I need to do it though. For my own sanity.

A moment of silence.

MARTIN
Couldn't you just do the crumpet bit? Everyone loves the crumpet bit.

KELLY
Oh yeah, the crumpet bit kills. But that's not what tonight is about.

MARTIN
Just promise me that... I worry about you, you know.

KELLY
I don't think you have to worry about that anymore.

MARTIN
Just... keep the crumpet bit in your back pocket. In case it gets too painful.

KELLY
If it does, I shall deploy the emergency crumpets.

MARTIN
Good. You know, we're family, right? And I'm Greta's family. So by the transitive property, you've got family in Norway.

Kelly smiles, taking one last peek at Kieran and Ash.

KELLY
I've got family here too. I don't think you need to worry about me...

Then she thinks better of it.

KELLY (cont'd)
...that much.

MARTIN
Just, check in, okay. There's a psychological term for what you're going through.

KELLY
That is?

MARTIN
You've got a screw loose.

Kelly laughs.

Kieran approaches the stage.

KELLY
Martin, gotta go. See you at Christmas.

MARTIN
Bye. Love ya.

KELLY
Love ya too.

Kelly heads back out on stage.

INT. KING OF STARS (STAGE) - NIGHT

She takes the microphone again.

KELLY
Right. Where were we?

INT. KELLY'S FLAT - NIGHT

Kelly and Martin play Switch on the couch. Greta makes coffee behind them.

ON KELLY'S SCREEN: *Zelda: Breath of the Wild*. Link disguised as a woman to enter the all-female Gerudo desert city.

MARTIN
I like Kelly.

KELLY
I like you too, Martin.

MARTIN
I mean the name, you big dummy! Irish flavour. Good mouthfeel.

KELLY
No new monogrammed luggage.

MARTIN
It suits you.

MARTIN (cont'd)
Your stand-up got better. You looked more comfortable.

Kelly sets down the game, looks at him.

KELLY
I mean, before, I was performing as a man performing comedy. Now it's just... the mic and me.

MARTIN
That tracks.

ON MARTIN'S SCREEN: *Super Metroid*. Samus, in full armour.

MARTIN (cont'd)
You gonna tell them?
(beat)
You don't have to.

KELLY
I, uh... yeah. I'm going to do it when I go home for Thanksgiving. I think I need to do this in person, if I'm going to.

Martin puts his switch down, and turns, giving Kelly his full attention.

MARTIN
It's going to eat you up inside if you don't tell them, isn't it?

KELLY
Yeah.
(long beat)
I mean, what kind of a son--

MARTIN
Daughter.

KELLY
--daughter, good catch. What kind of a daughter am I if I can tell strangers from a stage but not the people who love me most?
(beat)
I want them to see I'm still me. Just... happier. They always said that's what they wanted. And I always felt guilty that I couldn’t be happy for them.
(beat)
If I don't do it now, I'll lose my nerve. And they're getting older. Not to be morbid, but... how much time do we have?
(beat)
Besides it'll be nice to see Aunt Megan, Uncle Shane... Laika.

MARTIN
I get it. I worry about you, but I get it.

KELLY
Will you be there with me?

Martin glances at Greta. She shakes her head.

MARTIN
I would. But we burned our leave coming here. We're saving what's left for Christmas in the States.

GRETA
(Norwegian accent)
He promised me Disneyworld!

KELLY
Dawww...

MARTIN
But have me on video. I *really* want to see their faces.

Kelly stares at him.

MARTIN (cont'd)
--and for support.

KELLY
I'll take any support I can get.
(beat)
Actually, if Mom still has them... can I try your old bras?

Martin recoils.

MARTIN
We agreed never to speak of those again.

EXT. THE SKY - NIGHT TO DAY

A plane leaves London in darkness, descends into North Carolina sunlight. American flags near the runway.

SUPER: November, 2022

EXT. AIRPORT CURBSIDE PICKUP - DAY

Kelly rolls her bags, male-presenting in jeans and T-shirt.

A polished pickup idles. POW/MIA sticker. A peeling "Support Our Troops" ribbon.

Colleen (68) steps out from the passenger seat -- wearing ridiculous Groucho Marx glasses.

Kelly stops. Blinks. Then laughs.

Rory (73) steps out from the driver's side.

He hugs her, lifts her slightly, then remembers himself.

His jacket shifts -- the outline of a shoulder holster.

LAIKA (dog, Siberian Husky) scrambles over the seat divider, whining with joy.

INT. RORY'S TRUCK - DAY

Rory drives, Kelly beside him, Colleen and Laika in back. Dog paraphernalia everywhere: blankets, leashes, kibble in the cupholder, nose smudges on the window.

Colleen reaches forward and brushes dog hair off Kelly's shoulder. It instantly reappears.

Laika leans between the seats and licks Kelly's face.

RORY
Laika. *Boundaries*.

The dog happily ignores him.

EXT. NORTH CAROLINA HIGHWAY - DAY

Rory's truck moves with traffic. The road widens into a suburban artery.

They pass a subdivision: LET'S GO BRANDON banner. A Trump flag larger than the American flag. Faded Trump/Pence sign -- Pence spray-painted out. A lifted pickup with a Thin Blue Line decal.

Green highway sign: COLONIAL CROSSING, NC.

Rory signals and takes the exit.

INT. RORY'S TRUCK - DAY

Laika wedges her snout between the seats, sniffing the cupholder kibble. Kelly and Rory pet her.

Rory unzips his jacket. T-shirt: MY HUSKY IS SMARTER THAN YOUR HONOR STUDENT.

Below it -- the BLACK PISTOL in a shoulder holster.

Rory adjusts the holster like it's a belt, then uses the same hand to give Laika a treat.

KELLY
Dad... you brought a gun *to an airport?*

RORY
I didn’t go inside. I keep it safe. Not a big deal. And Two-A is important.

KELLY
I live in London now. On purpose.

COLLEEN
I worry about you there. You're Irish.

KELLY
American-Irish. Completely different.

COLLEEN
Says who?

KELLY
The *Irish*. Besides, I've assimilated. I have opinions on tea now. I've learned to blend. Ba-dum-tish!

Colleen groans.

RORY
Collie-dear, doesn't your brother have connections with the IRA?

Kelly stares at Rory. He's serious. She turns to Colleen. She isn't laughing.

KELLY
Shane? He's never even been to Ireland. You sure this isn't like his Sasquatch story?

COLLEEN
He worked for the Port Authority in Boston in the 90s. He knew people. Boston, you know? That's all I'm saying.

KELLY
You think you know someone--

Kelly winces.

The truck turns into the neighbourhood. Trump and MAGA flags reflect across Kelly's face in the window.

EXT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - DAY

Rory's truck pulls into the driveway.

Colleen grabs the carry-on. Kelly wrestles the big suitcase. Rory wrangles Laika.

KELLY (V.O.) (PRE-LAP)
You'd think this part would be easy.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE (FRAMING DEVICE) - NIGHT

KELLY
I mean, my brother broke the O'Connell family trans ceiling twenty years ago.
(pause)
Didn't mean I wasn't terrified. I had no idea how they'd react when I told them I was a *lesbian*.
(laughter)
Could've gone either way -- quiet support... or my dad yelling:
(imitating)
"Nobody in this family's getting a coochie installed unless they plan to stuff it with penis like the good Lord intended!"

Laughter.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY

Kelly sits slightly offset beneath a hanging crucifix. Colleen occupies one of two matching recliners.

Kelly sets a laptop on the coffee table. Martin appears on-screen.

COLLEEN
So, Kevin, what's the big news?

KELLY
We should wait for Dad.

RORY (O.S.)
I'm coming, I'm coming.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - MASTER BEDROOM - DAY

Rory hangs up his jacket. He removes the holster and pistol. Locks it in a bedside safe. CLICK.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY

Rory enters, rests a hand on Colleen's shoulder. She smiles up at him.

RORY
So, you've got news?

Kelly squirms.

KELLY
Yeah, actually, and it's kinda big...

COLLEEN
Oh God, it's cancer!

KELLY
What? No!

RORY
You got your girlfriend pregnant?

COLLEEN
You have a *girlfriend*?

KELLY
No. Nobody's pregnant. No one has cancer. Nobody has a girlfriend.

MARTIN
I have a girlfriend.

KELLY
You have a *wife*.

MARTIN
She's *also* my girlfriend.

Greta pops on-screen.

GRETA
Hello!

Gone again.

COLLEEN
But seriously, you should keep an eye on that. Cancer runs in our family.

RORY
And always use a condom.

COLLEEN
No kids until you're married!
(pointing to crucifix)
You may not believe in God... but you're still *Catholic*.

Kelly squints at the crucifix -- reaches behind it, pulls out a Monopoly bill.

KELLY
I'm forty-three, Mom.

MARTIN
Teen pregnancy drops off sharply after twenty.

KELLY
Martin, you're not helping.

COLLEEN
For heaven's sake, what is it?

KELLY
It's just... Martin might not be the only trans person in the family.

Silence. Colleen's face falls.

COLLEEN
Oh.

Rory turns, heads for the kitchen.

KELLY
Dad?

RORY
I'm refilling my coffee. I'm going to need coffee for this.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - KITCHEN - DAY

Rory grabs a Darth Vader #1 DAD mug, starts the machine. Laika sits hopefully.

RORY
Laika. Vet said no. No coffee for puppies.

Laika whines. Rory looks heartbroken.

RORY (cont'd)
Laika, we've *talked* about this.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY

Colleen sits, confused and shaken.

COLLEEN
It doesn't make sense.

KELLY
No Mom. It finally *does*. All my life. The depression. The fog. I knew something was missing.

Rory re-enters with his coffee.

COLLEEN
And that something was a...

She can't say it. Grimaces. Makes a V with her hands.

KELLY
I mean, psychologically.
(beat)
--though...

RORY
Jesus.

Colleen glares. Martin facepalms.

KELLY
Forget that. Point is, when I look at my life through this lens, the math finally adds up.

Colleen reaches for Rory's hand. He takes it, still standing.

COLLEEN
Give me a moment.

They sit in silence. Rory sits beside her.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
Could it be the autism?

KELLY
If anything, I'm enjoying my autism. I'm a software engineer. I get to be autistic professionally.

Rory nods, considering.

RORY
You think it could be something genetic?

KELLY
Absolutely.

Rory leans back.

RORY
Agent Orange. They say it can pass things on.

MARTIN
Dad, please stop diagnosing things as Agent Orange.

KELLY
Wait... could it?

Kelly turns to Martin. Martin shakes his head.

Colleen leans forward.

COLLEEN
How can you be *sure?*

Kelly takes a breath.

KELLY
Okay. Don't get upset.
(beat)
I tried something. An experiment.

She hands Colleen an empty oestrogen patch sachet.

KELLY (cont'd)
Oestrogen. And T-blockers.

Colleen stiffens. Kelly takes her hand.

KELLY (cont'd)
It's the best antidepressant I've ever taken.

Colleen stares at the sachet, stunned.

Rory stands, overwhelmed.

RORY
Right. I need fresh air.

He steps outside. Laika follows.

EXT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - BACK DECK - DAY

Rory tosses a tennis ball for Laika. His expression unreadable.

He throws. Laika sprints across the yard.

Rory doesn't watch her. He stares into the distance.

Laika returns, drops the ball at his feet. Rory throws it again. Laika runs. Rory keeps staring.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY

Colleen closes her eyes, takes a steadying breath.

COLLEEN
There's one thing I don't get.

MARTIN
One?

COLLEEN
Oestrogen gave me terrible mood swings, cramps, and... ugh. I don't understand how it can be an antidepressant.

KELLY
I don't know either. My brain just runs better on oestrogen than testosterone.

Colleen grabs Kelly's hands.

COLLEEN
Honey, sweetie.
(beat)
Everyone's brain runs better on oestrogen than testosterone.

KELLY
Mom, Martin's *right here*.

MARTIN
Yeah, no. Gotta go with Mom on this one. I've gotten a little dumber on testosterone. At least according to Greta.

Kelly squints at Martin through the screen.

COLLEEN
Have you considered maybe you're getting older and need *more* testosterone and--

KELLY
Mom. No. Really.
(beat)
I wouldn’t say this if I wasn’t sure.
(beat)
Something finally fits the data.

Awkward silence.

MARTIN
Kevin and I have been talking about this for months. They're not rushing into it.

COLLEEN
I suppose, like Martin, you're going to want a new name.

KELLY
Yeah.

COLLEEN
What is it?

Kelly takes Colleen's hands and looks into her eyes with absolute sincerity.

KELLY
Boomquifa.

A beat.

COLLEEN
What?

KELLY
I want you to call me Boomquifa.

COLLEEN
(frozen)
Boomquifa.

KELLY
Boomquifa O'Connell.

Martin recoils. Colleen goes pale.

Kelly breaks.

KELLY (cont'd)
No. I'm kidding, Mom.

COLLEEN
Thank God.

KELLY
Just preparing you. Figured anything after that would be a relief.

COLLEEN
Honey. Doesn't work that way.
(beat)
Just tell me.

KELLY
(hesitating)
Kelly.

Colleen winces -- then goes very still.

KELLY (cont'd)
You don't like it.

COLLEEN
I mean... it's better than *Boomquifa?*

KELLY
...okay?

MARTIN
It works. Irish-ish. Familiar.

COLLEEN
What's wrong with... *Kevina*?

A silent pause.

KELLY
Everything.

More silence, Kelly is giving Colleen time to process.

COLLEEN
It was different with Martin.
It... made *sense* with Martin.

Then Colleen shakes her head, determination.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
Wait... wait a minute. You can't
be trans! You're not even *gay*.

KELLY
I mean, I'm not gay.
(beat)
No -- wait -- I am gay. On a
technicality. Gay for women.
(beat)
Lesbian with an asterisk.
(beat)
I'm only gay because I slipped in
through the back door...

MARTIN
Kelly. Stop.

Rory comes back in with Laika, who immediately heads over and licks Kelly's hand.

COLLEEN
You didn't wear my dresses, didn't
put on makeup. Martin kept
stealing your underwear, for
crying out loud!

MARTIN
You knew about that?

KELLY
I could give a TED Talk on why
those "signs" are nonsense.

MARTIN
Please don't. It's getting late in
Norway, I'll fall asleep.

KELLY
The only sign that matters? Every step
I take, the pain gets quieter.
(MORE)

KELLY (cont'd)
(beat)
You always said you wanted us happy.
(beat)
This is how I get there.

There's a moment of quiet after that.

KELLY (cont'd)
Dad? You okay?

Rory won't look at Kelly.

RORY
I mean, hell, you're forty-three, you're a grown man, you can do whatever the hell you want. Not much I can say about it.
(beat)
We want you to be happy.
(beat)
We *do*.
(beat)
Whatever makes you *happy*.

A long pause.

RORY (cont'd)
Yeah.
(beat)
I'll take the dog for a walk.

Laika leaps up and over to Rory at "walk."

Rory returns in coat and newsboy cap, pistol visible again beneath the open jacket. He grabs poo bags and Laika's lead.

RORY (cont'd)
Here, Laika! C'mon Laika-girl. Let's go for a walk.

Rory takes a dog lead that was hanging on the wall, Laika happily following. He leaves with Laika. The door creaks shut.

Silence stretches.

KELLY
I think... Dad needs a little bit of time.

COLLEEN
He does.
(long beat)
I do too.

Colleen gets up.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
I have questions.

KELLY
I'm sure you do.

COLLEEN
But right now, I need to lie down.

MARTIN
Okay. I'll be here if you need me.

KELLY
Yeah, we can pick this up later.

Colleen nods, heads to the bedroom.

A moment.

KELLY (cont'd)
I think that went well.

Martin glares through the camera at Kelly.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

Kelly performs a customer-service-call bit.

KELLY (AS JESUS)
Heaven: you shiv 'em, we forgive 'em. Jesus speaking.

Laughter.

KELLY (AS COLLEEN)
Yes, Jesus... this is Colleen O'Connell. I'm calling about an order I placed for a healthy son and a healthy daughter? The labels got switched.
(beat)
Is it possible... you made a mistake?

KELLY (AS JESUS)
Whoa, whoa. God doesn't make mistakes.

KELLY (AS COLLEEN)
Oh. Right.

KELLY (AS JESUS)
However...
(beat)
He does enjoy a good practical joke.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - KITCHEN - NIGHT

The kitchen wall clock ticks. An open pizza box. Paper plates. Garlic sauce.

Martin remains on-screen, now in pyjamas.

Colleen dips a crust into garlic sauce, then turns to Kelly.

COLLEEN
Okay. I have to ask. Why *now?*

Kelly swallows.

KELLY
I didn't have the words before. Now people are telling their stories... and they sound like mine.

COLLEEN
What kind of stories?

KELLY
A comic I saw online.

COLLEEN
Good lord.

She reaches for her rosary -- not there.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
A *comic book?*

KELLY
More of a comic strip...

Colleen puts down her pizza.

COLLEEN
(horrified)
You got your gender... from *Hägar the Horrible*.

MARTIN
No, that was me.
(beat)
Now I'm a bearded man living in Scandinavia.

KELLY
Mom, the comic I read, the author figured out she was trans a few years ago and wrote about it. It felt like she had a direct line into my brain.

The tension eases--slightly.

COLLEEN
And you've really made up your mind?

KELLY
About being trans, yes. About what I do next? I don't know yet. I'm taking it slow.

RORY
Slow is good.

He folds a napkin carefully.

RORY (cont'd)
No sense doing something you can't undo.

He takes a bite. Chews. Too long.

KELLY
I'll stay low-key. At least for now. Except where I know I'm safe.

COLLEEN
I suppose I'll have to get used to this then.
(beat)
Kelly... you have to understand... this feels like my son just died.
(beat)
I'm going to need time to... mourn.

Kelly looks away.

KELLY
Mom... I've been trying to die for thirty years. Now I'm finally not.
(beat)
Doesn't that count?

Silence.

COLLEEN
I know.
(beat)
I just... don't feel it?

Colleen presses her thumb through the crust, folds it around the dent.

KELLY
That's why I came home. I'm still me. Still the kid you raised. Let me show you I'm not a stranger.

COLLEEN
(quiet)
I'm glad you're here. I *am*. I love you so much.
(beat)
And you too, Martin.

MARTIN
If it makes you--

His video freezes. Resumes.

MARTIN (cont'd)
--relax, I know Kelly's got this.
(beat)
She's braver than I am. Maybe not as clever.

KELLY
Hey!

MARTIN
She's the Sherlock to my Mycroft.

KELLY
Yeah, if Sherlock missed every obvious clue for thirty years.

Colleen studies Kelly's face. Trying.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - KELLY'S ROOM - NIGHT

Light on. Kelly enters. Everything too neat -- preserved, not lived in.

Cracked ergonomic chair. Shelves of computer manuals, sci-fi, history, journalism.

A framed graduation photo. Forced smile.

Kelly's reflection catches in the glass.

Kelly opens the closet.

Inside: Men's suits hang carefully spaced.

She pushes them aside. The hanger dents remain.

She opens her suitcase. Jeans. T-shirts. Functional. Unremarkable.

The FLORAL DRESS stands out. She hangs it in the centre of the closet.

She places foundation, brush, lipstick on the dresser with care.

The rest of the clothes she shoves into a drawer.

She heads to the door -- stops. Hears:

COLLEEN (O.S.)
I don't understand.

RORY (O.S.)
Shh, it's alright.

COLLEEN (O.S.)
I had that one cigarette when I was pregnant with Martin... but with Kevin? I didn't even have artificial sweetener.

Kelly closes the door gently. The crying muffles.

She sets up her laptop on the desk. Lifts a pair of headphones... hesitates.

A muffled sob breaks through.

Kelly slides them on.

On the laptop: the first video of her performing as Kelly. Her reflection merges with the screen image.

INSERT: VIDEO

KIERAN (ON-SCREEN)
--be part of Kelly's new family.
(applause)
Ladies and Gentlemen, Kelly O'Connell!

The audience cheers.

BACK TO SCENE

Kelly watches. A small smile.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

[NOTE: This is the framing device in December 2022, not the first performance.]

KELLY
Am I going to tell you that transition has solved all my problems? No. For one, it has done nothing to help me track down the one-armed killer who framed me for the murder of my wife.

Laughter.

KELLY (cont'd)
But it has helped my depression. I used to get so depressed in winter, I barely had the energy or motivation to put up the Christmas noose.

Laughter, with some groans.

INT. COLLEEN'S CAR - DAY

Laughter overlaps with the low hum of an engine.

Colleen drives, Kelly beside her.

COLLEEN
(shocked, but laughing)
Kelly, you shouldn't make jokes like that.

KELLY
Mom, I don't even know how to tie a noose.
(beat)
I'd need a clip-on noose.

Colleen snorts.

COLLEEN
Kevin -- er, Kelly -- no. Stop it.

KELLY
Making jokes about my depression was how I got through it. A lot of people like me... don’t make it to middle age. Not if we haven't figured it out.

Kelly squirms, clears her throat.

KELLY (cont'd)
Point is, my dark sense of humour might have been the thing that saved me.

COLLEEN
You know... you were diagnosed with depression first, then Martin. That's what made me get assessed.

KELLY
Sure, but Martin and I turned out to be trans too.
(teasing)
What do you think, Mom? Think you might be trans?

COLLEEN
(quiet, serious)
Oh no, Kelly. It's too late for me.

Kelly turns to her.

Colleen keeps driving. Signals. The blinker clicks in the silence.

EXT. UPSCALE OUTLET STORE (PARKING LOT) - DAY

Colleen's car pulls into a space. Kelly and Colleen step out.

They walk past parked cars. Kelly clocks the familiar Trump and Thin Blue Line stickers.

KELLY
You okay with this?

COLLEEN
I did it with Martin. Fair's fair.

Colleen nervously straightens her blouse.

KELLY
(quiet)
It helps... you being here.

Colleen grips her purse strap, knuckles paling.

INT. UPSCALE OUTLET STORE - DAY

Mannequins: petite, perfect, identical. Kelly studies them, frowning.

KELLY
(sotto)
Attention shoppers: real women wear size four and smile. Good luck, linebacker.

Colleen browses, alert to the room. A SHOPPER glances at them.

Colleen selects a hyper-feminine dress. Smooths the fabric.

COLLEEN
Ke--Kelly.

Kelly turns and joins her.

KELLY
Sorry. In my head. What is it?

COLLEEN
What about this?

Kelly eyes it.

KELLY
It's a little... *fru-fru*.

COLLEEN
Isn't fru-fru *good*?

KELLY
I'm aiming for daily wear. Not coronation day.

COLLEEN
No dresses?

KELLY
Dresses are fine. But even Disney princesses would be embarrassed by that.
(beat)
Less Belle in the ballroom, more Merida axe-throwing.

A blue flannel "boyfriend shirt" catches Kelly's eye.

KELLY (cont'd)
Oh. Hello. This I could live in.

Colleen blinks.

COLLEEN
Kelly...

KELLY
Yes?

COLLEEN
Those are called *boyfriend shirts*.

KELLY
I like flannel. Lots of lesbians wear flannel.

COLLEEN
Butch lesbians wear flannel.
(lower)
And they get hurt for it.

KELLY
The Neanderthals aren't doing taxonomy, Mom.
(beat)
I just like it. Maybe I'm butch.

COLLEEN
I just don't understand the point of being a woman if you're just going to look like k.d. lang.

Kelly absorbs that. Then:

KELLY
There isn't a point. There's who I am, and who I like to look like.
(beat, quieter)
And I want to look like a woman, not--

COLLEEN
-- a man in a dress?

Silence. Kelly swallows the reply.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
I'm sorry.
(beat)
If you're happy, that's what matters.
(beat)
I just don't always know what happy looks like on you anymore.

They separate to different racks.

Colleen lifts pink sundresses. Kelly gravitates toward neutral casual-wear.

They try to show each other options. Neither approves. The physical distance between them grows. Shopping in parallel.

Colleen holds up a YELLOW ROMPER.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
This is adorable. You'd look... darling.

Kelly forces a smile.

KELLY
I can try it.

She heads toward the fitting rooms. Colleen pales, scanning the other shoppers, and touches her arm.

COLLEEN
(quiet, urgent)
Let's not. Not today.
(beat)
I don't want anyone to be cruel to you.
(beat)
We can try them at home. Return what doesn't work. Safer that way.

SFX: TEXT ALERT.

Colleen checks her phone.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
Aunt Megan wants to know if we want lunch.

KELLY
I'm starving. What's she suggesting?

EXT. INDIAN RESTAURANT - DAY

Colleen and Kelly arrive. Kelly carries a shopping bag. The YELLOW ROMPER peeks out.

AUNT MEGAN (late 60s), exuberant and unstoppable, barrels over and hugs Kelly tight.

MEGAN
How ya' been, toots!

Over Kelly's shoulder, Megan clocks Colleen's frozen smile. Softens -- then the trickster grin returns.

MEGAN (cont'd)
Oh, thank God. You told her.

KELLY
Yeah.

COLLEEN
Wait-- what?

MEGAN
Colleen, I love ya, but your poker face is worse than a nun's at *Magic Mike*. Glad you finally know, too. I was running out of ways to not blurt it out during after-mass brunch.

COLLEEN
Blurt *what* out?

KELLY
Mom, I, uh... told Aunt Megan first. On the phone.

COLLEEN
You told Aunt Megan *first*?

Kelly winces.

KELLY
I didn't want to say it wrong and make it worse. I needed a test run.

MEGAN
Boy, did she ever. Opened with: "Hey, Auntie M, I have good news and bad news.
(MORE)

MEGAN (cont'd)
Good news: I found the source of my lifelong depression. Bad news: it's in my scrotum."

Colleen turns slowly to Kelly. Kelly withers. A beat.

COLLEEN
Okay, yeah, you *did* need a test run. Good Lord, Kelly. Do not bring up your scrotum unless I specifically ask.
(beat)
I won't.

INT. INDIAN RESTAURANT - DAY

A suburban Indian spot. Menus, water, yogurt on the table.

MEGAN
I want the vindaloo but at my age spicy food is a *medical event*. The eternal struggle.

Colleen smirks, slides Megan water. Kelly slides the yogurt. Identical motions.

MEGAN (cont'd)
So, how's life in the land of the oppressors?

KELLY
Complicated. London's great. I love it. But it's getting rough for trans people in England.

COLLEEN
Have you thought about moving back here?

KELLY
I haven't ruled it out. Somewhere queer-friendly I can afford. Maybe Vegas?

Colleen frowns. Megan lights up.

COLLEEN
Not Vegas. It's nothing but insanity, chaos, and risk.

MEGAN
You'd be mayor by Friday.

COLLEEN
Why not Raleigh? Be close to home.

KELLY
Safety.

Colleen fiddles with her napkin. The teen waiter brings poppadoms.

KELLY (cont'd)
If I can make London work, I will. I've got friends, know the culture, and the stand-up scene's the best in the world.

Megan grabs her phone.

MEGAN
Oh--I can show your mother your set now!

Email sent. Colleen's phone pings.

MEGAN (cont'd)
It's her act. It's phenomenal.

Colleen's phone rings: FOOD BANK.

COLLEEN
Colleen O'Connell speaking... Oh, for the love of -- hold on.

She covers the phone.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
Food bank crisis. They need me. Sorry to cut lunch short.

MEGAN
Thanksgiving. Everything's on fire. I'll run Kelly home. Go be a saint.

COLLEEN
You okay with that, Kelly?

KELLY
Gives us time to catch up. Go. You still need two more miracles before canonization.

COLLEEN
Okay, kiddo. Love you.

KELLY
Love you too, Mom.

Colleen hugs Kelly, then exits.

EXT. INDIAN RESTAURANT - DAY

Outside, Colleen stops. Eyes closed. Exhales.

Her shoulders drop. Then she walks faster.

INT. INDIAN RESTAURANT - DAY

Megan and Kelly watch Colleen through the window.

MEGAN
Honestly, I think your mother's relieved.

KELLY
...relieved?

MEGAN
Last time she ordered butter chicken "as mild as allowed by law." Whole Catholic martyr bit -- fanning herself, offering it up to Jesus.

Kelly processes.

KELLY
Oh.
(beat)
Right. That.
(beat)
Speaking of which, I need to use the loo.

MEGAN
Oh, look at you, all hoity-toity. With your *loo* and your *crumpets*.

Kelly turns toward the clearly gendered bathrooms. Her face falls.

MEGAN (cont'd)
Kelly.

Kelly looks back.

MEGAN (cont'd)
If anybody gives you crap about needing to crap, I've got your back.

Kelly smiles, pats Megan's hand.

KELLY
Thank you.

At the women's restroom, Kelly hesitates. Reaches for the door--

Something CRUNCHES beneath her shoe.

A broken plastic "W."

She looks up at the damaged sign:

OMEN.

KELLY (cont'd)
Well that's not a good sign.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

KELLY
So while I am a lesbian, I'm kind of a clearance-rack lesbian. Slightly irregular.
(beat)
I'm taking hormones, not opposed to a surgery or two... so if any lesbians here are interested, I am available.
(beat)
For pre-order.

Laughter.

EXT. BIG BOX STORE/TARGET - DAY

Kelly and Megan are walking along the outlet stores until they get to a big box store. They talk as they walk, Kelly still holding her bag, with the yellow romper in it. Kelly also has a take-home cup of ice tea with a straw.

MEGAN
So. Any luck on the romance front?

KELLY
I'm not ready. I can't be anyone's boyfriend.

Megan laughs.

KELLY (cont'd)
Right. Girlfriend. Still getting used to that.

Kelly glances to the store entrance as two women, holding hands, walk out together. She looks at them with resigned envy.

INT. BIG BOX STORE/TARGET - DAY - CONTINUOUS

Megan grabs a shopping cart. She places her purse in the child-seat. Kelly puts her romper bag in the cart.

KELLY
Lesbians don't want a woman who looks like a man. Straight women don't want... women.

MEGAN
Sweetheart, there are lesbians at my church who'd crawl across glass for you.

Kelly gives her a look.

MEGAN (cont'd)
They're old. But they're spry.

Kelly snorts. The two continue walking towards the women's section.

INT. BIG BOX WOMEN'S SECTION - DAY - CONTINUOUS

They approach the women's section. Megan picks up a pink t-shirt that says "OWN WHO YOU ARE," from a table, and tosses it to Kelly.

Kelly catches it, then, surprised, she feels the fabric.

KELLY
Huh. Softer than I expected.

MEGAN
You know, I went out this weekend. Guy-- Greg.

KELLY
Really? What's he like?

Kelly sips the ice tea.

MEGAN
Nice enough. Rodeo. Steakhouse. Then over dinner he mentions he's in the Klan.

Kelly nearly spit-takes.

KELLY
Jesus.

Megan looks guilty.

KELLY (cont'd)
Aunt Megan...

MEGAN
Other than the Klan thing... we're compatible. There were sparks.

KELLY
A fork and a wall socket are technically compatible. Sparks too.

Megan deflates.

MEGAN
Kelly, I'm nearly seventy. Do you know how low your standards sink before bigotry isn't a deal-breaker?

She fidgets with her ring finger. No ring.

MEGAN (cont'd)
I know he's trash. I just forget sometimes that I'm not.

Kelly absorbs that.

KELLY
Being desired is nice. Pretending to be someone else for approval will make you insane.

Megan eyes the yellow romper Colleen bought in the bag.

MEGAN
Maybe take your own advice?

Kelly pauses.

KELLY
Okay. I'm a hypocrite. Just... give me time.

Megan squeezes her hand. She picks out a nice short-sleeved blouse. Shows it to Kelly, who gives a thumbs up.

MEGAN
I get it. You're staying safe. That's survival. I don't want to eat dinner alone.

Megan puts the shirt in the cart.

KELLY
Just... don't set the bar so low it's a tripping hazard in Hell. The Devil will dare you to limbo.

MEGAN
I just wish I had what your parents had.

KELLY
Neuroses?

MEGAN
Got those. I mean fidelity. Stability.

She fidgets with her ring finger again.

MEGAN (cont'd)
Near the end my ex was cheating. I pretended not to notice. I think I was less upset about the cheating and more upset about his horrible taste in women.

KELLY
Why stay?

MEGAN
Nobody around me talked about divorce. The nuns warned us it was a sin. Shoulda warned us about marrying a dumbass.

Kelly laughs.

INT. BIG BOX LADIES DRESSING RM. - DAY - MOMENTS LATER

Kelly is in the dressing room. We can see the top of her head over the door. Megan brings over a longline sleeveless cardigan, and hangs it over the door.

MEGAN
Try wearing this over the t-shirt.

KELLY
What is it?

MEGAN
A longline sleeveless cardigan. Try some layering. You can do a lot with layers.

KELLY
Hunh. Didn't know that. I'll give it a try.

MEGAN
Saw my ex last month. Our granddaughter was having her appendix taken out. We're sitting there, waiting for the doctor, and he turns to me and says:
(disgusted)
"When I think about you, I still get hard."

KELLY
Oh my god. Ew.

MEGAN
I'm living proof being a lesbian isn't a choice. Because *men*.

KELLY
Glad I defected.

Kelly steps out to show Megan the outfit, wearing the pink t-shirt, a longline sleeveless cardigan, and blue-jeans. Tags still on.

Megan gives her an approving thumbs up.

KELLY (cont'd)
(shrug)
Though I have to admit, I still think the Three Stooges are funny.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

KELLY
Two patches of oestrogen a week and I still think the Three Stooges are funny.
(beat)
I still hold babies like they're live grenades.
(beat)
And I still enjoy Yorkie bars, which used to say NOT FOR GIRLS like an allergy warning for snips, snails and puppy-dog tails.

(PRE-LAP) Laughter continues under the cut before ambient morning sound takes over.

EXT. SUBURBAN MORNING DOG WALK - DAY

Laika's tail swishes.

Rory walks Laika down a wooded street, Kelly beside him in boy-mode. Rory's "concealed" BLACK PISTOL is anything but.

RORY
Figured we could talk. Just you, me and Laika. Since Mom got her turn. How'd it go?

KELLY
She's trying. But...

RORY
Yeah, I get it. That yellow dress your mom picked? Ridiculous.

KELLY
Just not my style.
(beat)
There was a flannel shirt there I liked.

RORY
You look good in flannel. Keeps you warm in London.
(beat)
Honestly, nothing wrong with what you're wearing now.

KELLY
True, but when I dress like this, people see a man.

RORY
What's wrong with that?

KELLY
I'm not a man.

Rory shakes his head.

RORY
I don't really get it. Martin can dress like a guy, take testosterone... but he's still my girl.

Kelly exhales through her nose.

RORY (cont'd)
Why not just be a man?

KELLY
Why not just be a woman, Dad? Could you?

RORY
Why would I want to? I'm a man.

KELLY
Exactly. It feels right to you.

RORY
Yeah. Because I'm a man.

KELLY
Right.
(steady)
You and Martin both live as men. The difference is: he's trans. You're cis.

RORY
"Cis." What's that?

Kelly stops walking.

KELLY
Cisgender.

RORY
Right, but what does it mean?

She stares.

KELLY
Dad... Martin came out twenty years ago and you never learned what "cisgender" means?

RORY
Never needed it.

Rory adjusts his holster. Laika bumps his hand; with the same hand, he gives her a treat.

KELLY
Do you really take that thing everywhere?

RORY
Yep. You never know.

KELLY
Right. The North Carolina Ninja epidemic.

RORY
Crime's up on the news. Old folks getting robbed.

KELLY
What news? Fox?

RORY
What difference does that make?

KELLY
It makes a difference.

Rory shrugs.

RORY
Well, if old men have guns, they won't get targeted.

KELLY
You just said they do.

RORY
...Anyway, without guns the government could take over.

KELLY
So guns stop the government overthrowing... the government?

RORY
Exactly.

VANCE (60s) approaches with his dog, Dino. The dogs explode with joy.

VANCE
Morning, Rory! Hey Laika!

Rory brightens.

RORY
Hey Vance! Hey Dino!
(to Vance)
This is my son, Kevin.

Kelly freezes, forces a polite smile.

KELLY
Nice to meet you.

Kelly's smile holds half a beat too long.

RORY
He's here for Thanksgiving. Lives in London.

VANCE
London! How exotic!
(beat)
Oh -- Susan at the kennel said Laika left his toy. Grab it next time?

Rory bristles.

RORY
Her toy. Laika's a *girl*.

A tiny twitch crosses Kelly's face.

Kelly absently scratches behind Laika's ear. Laika leans into Kelly's leg.

EXT. COLONIAL PARK - DAY

Kelly, Rory, and Laika pass a sign marking COLONIAL PARK, the historical re-enactment site. Off-season quiet. Locals and the occasional tourist drift through.

MARTHA (60s) sells "Colonial" baked goods beneath a sign: AUTHENTIC COLONIAL COFFEE — $4 (Oat milk extra). A DeLonghi machine hums nearby.

A noticeboard includes a VFW flyer: GUNS ARE NOT TOYS. LEARN TO HANDLE SAFELY.

Laika spots Martha first and lights up.

MARTHA
Hello, Laika! And hello Rory!

She produces a dog treat. Laika accepts, licking her hand. Then sniffs at the coffee machine.

RORY
Hey Martha. How are things?
(to Laika)
Laika... no coffee. Vet said not even decaf.

Martha smiles and squirts out a little bit of whipped cream in a little paper dish, and gives it to Laika.

MARTHA
Good. And who's this?

KELLY
I'm--

RORY
Martha, this is my eldest son. Kevin.

KELLY
(summoning calm)
I go by Kelly now.

Rory gives her a look. She meets it.

KELLY (cont'd)
Old family name. Very noble. There was a castle. We lost it in a regrettable incident with the English.
(beat)
I'm visiting from London. Too many Kevins there.

MARTHA
London! Must be exciting! Like in that movie with the wizards?

KELLY
(annoyed deadpan)
...You're thinking of New Zealand.

MARTHA
And there's too many Kevins?

KELLY
When I started work, there were already two Kevins: Kevin and New Kevin. So I became New New Kevin. Then they hired another Kevin.
(beat)
I switched to Kelly when they started referring to me as Old New New Kevin.

Rory studies the colonial muffins. Laika licks crumbs off the pavement, then Kelly's hand. Kelly scratches her behind the ear.

KELLY (cont'd)
(whispered)
Good girl.

MARTHA
Makes sense. Wouldn't have guessed there were that many Kevins in London, though.

KELLY
Oh yeah. Every Tom, Dick, and Harry's named Kevin.
(beat)
Brexit was mostly about reducing Kevins.

Martha tilts her head.

EXT. COLONIAL PARK - DAY - LATER

Kelly, Rory, and Laika pass a re-enactor in colonial uniform scrolling on his phone while sipping a Starbucks frappuchino.

RORY
One good thing about you living in England is that England doesn't have Biden.
(disgust)
Him and his son. That laptop-- they found all kinds of stuff on it. Emails, money, hookers... it's all there. They just don't want you to see it.

Kelly exhales.

KELLY
That laptop has no clean chain of custody, and nobody's shown Joe changed policy for Hunter.

Rory stares straight ahead. He hasn't heard a word.

RORY
How can you be so sure?

KELLY
Dad, I'm a software engineer with an M.A. in journalism. I know what I'm talking about.
(beat)
That laptop story's got more holes in it than Uncle Shane's Sasquatch encounter.

RORY
Bah. That school filled your head with professor crap. Marxism. Gender stuff. Whatever.

KELLY
Dad. Central Texas University isn't exactly Berkeley. Three more credits and I'd have qualified for a minor in Rodeo Science.

They walk in silence.

RORY
I still think Joe Biden's in on it somehow. I mean, if Joe's innocent, why not cut Hunter off?

Kelly stops walking.

Rory takes a few steps before turning back.

KELLY
Dad.
(beat)
Dad.
(heavy beat)
Can *you*, of all people, not understand a man *loving a son who disappoints him?*

Rory says nothing. He resumes walking.

Laika looks between them, unsettled.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY

Rory and Kelly enter. Rory disappears briefly to put the gun away, returns, unharnesses Laika.

Colleen battles a crossword with White-Out as Kelly hangs her coat.

KELLY
Hey, Mom.

COLLEEN
Kev-Kelly! Oh, thank goodness you're here.

KELLY
What is it?

COLLEEN
I'm stuck on this puzzle. Would you mind taking a look at it?

Colleen hands it over. Kelly studies it.

KELLY
17 down's wrong. "Often raised at inappropriate moments," Five letters, fourth letter is 'I'. Should be "Topic."

Colleen lifts her glasses, squints to take a better look.

INSERT - COLLEEN'S CROSSWORD: 17 down is written as "PENIS"

COLLEEN
What did I write down for... oh.

Colleen blushes.

KELLY
Aunt Megan was helping you with this one, wasn't she?

Colleen puts the crossword away.

COLLEEN
Anyway--what was that show you mentioned? The British one you thought I'd like?

KELLY
Oh yeah, do you have time now?

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT - LATER

Kelly and Colleen laugh at a British comedy panel show.

At the kitchen table, Rory works on his laptop, occasionally smiling over at them.

KELLY
You're not going to join us, Dad?

RORY
Not really my thing. But I like seeing you two enjoy it.

Kelly smiles back. Her father watching. Her mother beside her.

KELLY (ON-STAGE) (PRE-LAP)
That's family for you. Sometimes they surprise you.

On Rory's laptop: Google.

He types: GENDER SCIENCE STUDY

Top result: NHS ENGLAND — INDEPENDENT REVIEW OF GENDER IDENTITY SERVICES...

Rory clicks. Reads. Scrolls.

Frowns.

Scrolls back up, reads more carefully.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

KELLY
Of course, some family members are more surprising than others. My uncle Shane has lived a life of unbelievable adventures.
(beat)
Unbelievable in the sense that they're clearly not true.
(beat)
Like the time he once saw a Sasquatch drunk off his ass on Hennessey.

EXT. RALEIGH AIRPORT — DAY

Aunt Megan helps UNCLE SHANE (80) into her car. The smile never leaves his face-- the kind that forgives the world in advance.

INT. MEGAN'S CAR — DAY

Megan drives. Shane pats her hand with quiet gratitude, as if she’s done him a favour he can’t repay.

SHANE
Have you ever seen a Sasquatch, drunk off his ass on Hennessey?

MEGAN
Uh-huh.

She's heard it before.

SHANE
I have. He was drinking it straight from the bottle.
(MORE)

SHANE (cont'd)
Behind Cracker Barrel, '92. Hairy as all hell. And the smell! Face like an ape. Hands the size of a bread box. And he was hung like--

MEGAN
(interruption)
Yeah, Shane. I know.

SHANE
I mean, that's what they say about men with big feet.

Megan rolls her eyes.

MEGAN
How are things up in Boston?

SHANE
Cold. Wet. Damp.

MEGAN
How are the Sox doing?

Shane frowns, looks down at his feet.

SHANE
Same. I should change them when we get to your place.

A moment.

Oh. You mean the *Red* Sox. Sorry, I'm a little slower on the uptake these days.

MEGAN
Aren't we all?
(not casual)
I'm thinking about retiring.

SHANE
So am I.

MEGAN
Shane... you're already retired.

SHANE
I was wondering why work wasn't complaining about my absence.
(beat)
So, who else did Colleen invite?

MEGAN
Me, you, Declan and his girlfriend... and Ke--Kevin flew in from London.

SHANE
Martin's not coming?

MEGAN
He's spending Thanksgiving in Norway.

SHANE
I didn't know the Norwegians celebrated Thanksgiving. Ah. That stinks. Was looking forward to seeing him. Well... maybe that means this year's a break from all that queer stuff.

Megan bristles.

MEGAN
What do you mean by that?

SHANE
I hate talking about it. I never remember the lingo.

MEGAN
The *lingo?*

SHANE
I'm afraid I'll say the wrong thing. Hurt Martin by accident. Last time I needed a flowchart. Like "twink." Isn't that the Irish singer?
(beat)
I think my doorman's gay. Might've hit on me. Asked if I was a "power bottom." I told him mine's still hand-cranked.
(beat)
Nice guy, though.

Megan laughs--relieved.

Shane smiles, relieved she's laughing too.

MEGAN
Shane, are you making this up?

SHANE
(bittersweet)
That's the problem. I'm so old now, I can't tell.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY

Colleen sits in her recliner, watching Kelly's Greta-filmed early stand-up on her laptop. She laughs. Genuinely proud.

SFX: A CAR PULLS INTO THE DRIVEWAY.

She snaps the laptop shut too fast, sets it aside, heads for the door.

SFX: DOORBELL.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - ENTRY - CONTINUOUS

Colleen opens the door to DECLAN (40s, effortless, unexamined masculinity) and his girlfriend MAUREEN (30s, poised, unselfconscious femininity).

DECLAN
Auntie Colleen! Eyyyy!

He scoops her into a hug.

COLLEEN
Declan! Maureen!

Colleen hugs her too.

COLLEEN (cont'd)
Come in!

They enter. Declan drops onto the couch, sprawling. Maureen smooths her skirt before sitting.

MAUREEN
(to Colleen)
I love that dress!

COLLEEN
Thank you! It has pockets! How was the drive?

DECLAN
Stressful, as always. Thanksgiving traffic. Nobody knows how to drive.

MAUREEN
Dec, sweetie. Indoor voice.

DECLAN
Oh. Sorry. God, the turkey smells great!

COLLEEN
We're doing two this year. One traditional, one deep-fried. Rory's idea.

EXT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - BACK DECK - DAY

Rory beams in rubber gloves and leather apron. Kelly holds matching gear, unconvinced.

Five metres from the house, a turkey fryer boils ominously.

Kelly scrutinizes a dubiously thawed turkey.

KELLY
Roman seers used to predict catastrophe from studying bird carcasses.
(beat)
Now I know how they felt.

RORY
It should be fine if we follow the instructions.

KELLY
Where are the instructions?

RORY
I gave them to you.

They stare at each other. Kelly shakes her head, no. The oil bubbles just a little *too* aggressively.

KELLY
That oil looks way too hot.

RORY
It’s meant to be hot. I watched a video. You just... lower it slowly.

KELLY
Into boiling oil.

RORY
Peanut oil.

KELLY
Oh, well, that’s different. I was worried it was Quaker State.

Kelly pokes the turkey with her finger.

KELLY (cont'd)
Is that fully thawed?

RORY
It's been out since this morning.

KELLY
That's not an answer. It's a warning.

The back door opens. Declan comes out first, with a beer in hand. Maureen follows, followed by Colleen.

Rory lights up.

RORY
Declan!

DECLAN
Uncle Rory! Kevin! Great to see you!

KELLY
Hey, Declan.

DECLAN
Oh, Kevin, I don't know if you've met yet. This is my girlfriend, Maureen.

Kelly clocks Maureen’s painted nails, soft blouse, easy poise.

She offers a handshake instead of a hug. Maureen takes it warmly.

MAUREEN
Nice to meet you. Dec says you're hilarious.

KELLY
Mm.

RORY
Declan, you ready to go shooting Saturday?

DECLAN
Am I ever! So, what's all this?

RORY
Perfect timing, actually. Want to help me deep-fry a turkey?

KELLY
(sotto)
Oh no. He's found backup.

She backs away from Rory, and places the apron and gloves on a patio table.

KELLY (cont'd)
Dad, I’m not doing this.

She gestures to the fryer.

KELLY (cont'd)
I was not planning on facing death this trip.

Colleen gently takes Kelly by the arm, draws her aside.

COLLEEN
Say, could you help me grab a few things from the car?

KELLY
Sure, Mom.

They head toward the driveway.

We stay on Rory and Declan. Rory claps him on the back, pride glowing in a way Kelly never sees, his laugh dropping half an octave.

RORY
Hah! Come on. Let's get this turkey in the bath.
(beat, to Declan, lower voice, excited)
I can show you my toys while it cooks.

EXT. O'CONNELL DRIVEWAY - DAY

Colleen opens the trunk: Thanksgiving supplies, two bags.

Behind them, Rory hooks the turkey to the rack as Declan gears up.

KELLY
Thanks for the save back there. I've been thinking about sculpting my eyebrows, but I don't want them burned off.

Colleen paces.

COLLEEN
Kelly... I wanted to talk to you. About dinner. Your uncle Shane... he's getting up there. And your dad, too. We're at that age where we won't be around forever.

Kelly freezes.

KELLY
Is this about to get morbid?

No laugh. Kelly sets down the bag, leans against the bumper.

In the background, Rory and Declan are about to dip the turkey in the oil. They're moving slowly and carefully.

KELLY (cont'd)
Mom. C'mon. What's going on?

Colleen fidgets.

COLLEEN
Would you maybe... not wear a dress? Just be Kevin. Just for Thanksgiving.

Kelly rubs her temples.

The fryer surges. Rory and Declan flinch, but keep lowering the turkey.

KELLY
You never asked Martin to wear a dress.

COLLEEN
I know. It's just... so everyone's comfortable. Who wants drama on Thanksgiving? And Martin... was always--

KELLY
I get it. It's different.
(beat)
I'm not thrilled, but I get it. You want a Thanksgiving that's happy. Not...

COLLEEN
Dramatic.

KELLY
Yeah.

Kelly hangs her head. Behind her, the turkey finally disappears into the oil. No disaster... yet.

KELLY (cont'd)
Thanksgiving makes you happy.
(quiet)
So... one dinner as Kevin. One.

Colleen pulls her into a hug. Kelly hugs back.

Over Colleen’s shoulder: Kelly’s strained face. On Colleen’s: relief.

They break. Colleen exits.

Kelly turns around. In the trunk of the car: the bag with the YELLOW ROMPER.

She closes the trunk harder than necessary.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY

The kitchen table is somewhere between a gun-show booth and Lord of War. Through the window, the fryer bubbles.

Rory shows Declan an AR-15.

RORY
This is an AR-15.

DECLAN
Cool. An assault rifle!

RORY
It's not an assault rifle. That's just what the anti-gun lobby calls it.

DECLAN
(accepting)
Oh. Yeah. So what does AR stand for?

RORY
ArmaLite. The company that designed it.

DECLAN
Makes sense.
(beat)
Why not AL-15?

Rory thinks.

RORY
...no idea.

Kelly enters, sees the table, sighs.

Colleen is sitting in her recliner, unfazed, opening a crossword.

COLLEEN
(without looking)
You'll have those cleared off before dinner, right, hun?

RORY
Will do, Collie-dear.

Kelly moves into the kitchen. She opens the tea box -- pulls out a Monopoly dollar bill, then a tea bag.

Outside, the fryer ERUPTS with steam and a BANG.

Everyone looks.

It settles.

RORY (cont'd)
That's just moisture burning off.

DECLAN
Yeah. You always get that.

Kelly takes a breath. Looks through the cabinets for a kettle.

Another POP. Only Kelly reacts.

DECLAN (cont'd)
So, Uncle Rory, what's your concealed carry?

Rory shows the BLACK PISTOL.

RORY
Glock 19. Compact. Practical. The Toyota Corolla of guns.

DECLAN
Nothing flashy?

RORY
Flashy gets you killed. Practical keeps you alive.

Kelly can't find the kettle.

KELLY
Mom, do you still have the electric kettle?

COLLEEN
Bottom cabinet, right.

Declan looks at a SILVER REVOLVER on the table, points to it.

DECLAN
What about this one?

Declan checks the cylinder, spins it, snaps it shut -- always pointed safely away.

RORY
I'd stay away from revolvers.

DECLAN
Why?

RORY
Too simple. Nothing between the thought and the trigger.

COLLEEN
Oh, Kevin -- here's a good one. Highest point of achievement, or supplier of faulty hunting gear. Four letters.

KELLY
Acme.

Rory lifts a shotgun.

RORY
Now this one's a favourite.
Mossberg 500.

Kelly finds the kettle, rinses it.

RORY (cont'd)
I had the Second Amendment
engraved on it. Take a look.

He turns the shotgun to show Declan. The barrel sweeps directly across Kelly.

Kelly flinches and ducks.

KELLY
Jesus!

Nobody else reacts.

Rory lowers the gun.

RORY
Sorry, Kevin. Did I accidentally
muzzle you there?

Declan doesn't react. Colleen doesn't look up.

KELLY
Jesus, Dad. You keep it pointed
down for a reason!

RORY
Sorry about that.

KELLY
You're the one always going on
about gun safety.

RORY
Oh -- reminds me. You and Declan can
help me install a gun safe later.

KELLY
What happened to the old one?

RORY
Nothing. I'm adding a fourth.

KELLY
A fourth? How many guns do you
actually have?

RORY
About eighty-ish.

KELLY
(shocked)
Eighty-*ish?* You can't be a responsible gun owner if the number ends in "-ish."

RORY
I'm a collector.

KELLY
Mom's a collector too. Nobody dies if a *Hummel* accidentally discharges.

Silence.

RORY
You don't like guns. I get it. Why can't I have a little fun with my toys?

KELLY
Dad...
(beat)
It's not that I don't like guns. It's that I'm not safe on bad days.

Rory's jaw tightens. He says nothing. Kelly pinches the bridge of her nose.

KELLY (cont'd)
Forget it. We'll talk after Thanksgiving.
(beat)
But the first thing you ever taught me about guns was: "guns are not toys."

Kelly heads upstairs, abandoning the tea.

COLLEEN
Oh, Kevin -- unaware of what's right in front of you. Nine letters.

KELLY (O.S.)
Oblivious.

COLLEEN
No. Third letter's an S.

A long beat.

KELLY (O.S.)
Insensate?

COLLEEN
Insensate! Thank you, Kevin!

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

There's some residual laughter and pub sounds in the background.

KELLY
Families are--

SMASH CUT:

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - DAY

JUMP SCARE: CLOSE ON COLLEEN filling the frame.

COLLEEN
Kevin, Aunt Megan and Uncle Shane are here.

Kelly comes down, arranging a happy face -- genuinely glad to see them.

SHANE
Kevin! So good to see you! How's life in London?

KELLY
Damp, but good.

MEGAN
So... Kevin?

Kelly winces.

KELLY
Yeah, Auntie M. Kevin. All day.

Megan hugs her, tight. Shane joins, turning it into a group hug.

SHANE
And the stand-up? When am I going to see you on Letterman?

Kelly smiles.

KELLY
Working on it. Had a breakthrough. Stage presence is better.

Megan nudges her shoulder. Kelly nudges back.

SHANE
There was something important I forgot... ah well. It'll come back.

Shane drifts toward Maureen.

Megan gently guides Kelly toward the back deck. Kelly makes sure Megan keeps a wide berth from the deep-fryer.

SHANE (cont'd)
And you must be Declan's girlfriend.

Maureen offers her hand. Shane kisses it.

SHANE (cont'd)
Enchanté!

DECLAN
(playful)
Stop stealing my girlfriends, Uncle Shane!

SHANE
Me? Never!

Shane spots the guns. Concerned.

SHANE (cont'd)
Oh. Rory. Happy Thanksgiving.

RORY
Happy Thanksgiving, Shane. How are things in Boston?

SHANE
Eh. Pretty good. Uh...

He glances around, lowers his voice.

SHANE (cont'd)
(quiet)
You sending any of this to our boys in Derry?

A tiny beat of silence.

RORY
What?

SHANE
(concerned)
Rory, you're a good bloke, but I think we should give Good Friday a chance.

RORY
...what?

EXT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - BACK DECK - CONTINUOUS

Megan and Kelly enter the back deck for a quick check-in.

MEGAN
How are you holding up, Kelly?

KELLY
Just Kevin for today. This is Mom's holiday, you know.

MEGAN
Did Colleen ask for that?

KELLY
Weaponized Irish Catholic mom guilt.

MEGAN
I see. I'll follow your lead. Ke--

She stops, unsure.

KELLY
Kevin is fine.

MEGAN
Alright, Kevin. But I want you to know. You were right. I deserve better.
(beat)
Kelly.
(beat)
So do you.

Kelly exhales. Lets it land.

KELLY
You're right. But Mom’s barely holding it together. If I push, today becomes about me. And with Shane, Declan, Maureen... it’s a lot. I’ll decide who to tell and when. Nobody needs a Thanksgiving ambush.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Megan and Kelly step inside.

In the middle of the room, like a spectre: FATHER PATRICK (60s). Gaunt. Stern. Silent. Black hoodie up.

Megan registers mild surprise. Kelly freezes.

COLLEEN (O.S.)
Oh, Kevin -- this is Father Patrick, from the food bank. I invited him to Thanksgiving. He would've been on his own.

Wordlessly, Father Patrick removes the hoodie.

A priest's collar.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - DINING ROOM - DAY

Thanksgiving. Places: Rory at the head, Father Patrick at the end, right side from head, Colleen, Declan, Maureen, left side from head, Kelly, Megan, Shane.

Two turkeys. One oven-roasted to perfection. The fried one is over-charred on one side, blistered, warped and slightly collapsed. Not grotesque. Clearly wrong.

Plates pass. Everyone's already eating. We join in media res.

RORY
I think the fried turkey came out alright. Bit darker than expected, but that's the oil temp. Locks in the flavour.

DECLAN
(supportive)
Looks savage.

MAUREEN
So, Declan tells me you work at a food bank, Colleen?

COLLEEN
Mm. Yes -- Our Mother Of Mercy.

MAUREEN
What's it like?

COLLEEN
Exhausting, honestly. It seems like every year, there are more people who need help.

DECLAN
Yeah, people are struggling. Not much you can do.

Kelly slow blinks.

KELLY
I wouldn't say that--

MAUREEN
What would you say?

KELLY
When wages don't keep up with--

COLLEEN
Kevin, this is Thanksgiving. Is this the time for politics?

KELLY
I'm not--

RORY
We'll agree to disagree.

Forks clink. Someone chews too loudly.

KELLY
Sorry. I didn't mean--

RORY
Let's not get into it.

Shane smiles, confused.

SHANE
People used to help their neighbours more.

DECLAN
Exactly.

KELLY
Actually--

COLLEEN
There it is again.

MAUREEN
Kevin, sweetheart, no one's arguing with you.

Father Patrick clears his throat. Silence floods the space Kelly occupied.

Kelly nods. Picks up her fork. Doesn't eat.

DECLAN
People just want stability. Not handouts. Just a fair shot.

Kelly's fork hovers. She doesn't bite.

SHANE
You used to raise a family on one income.

COLLEEN
Exactly.

KELLY
People still want that life. They just can't afford it.

RORY
Kevin. That's enough.

COLLEEN
Why are you so angry all the time?

KELLY
I'm not angry.

The table stills.

COLLEEN
We just don't want a fight.

KELLY
I know.

RORY
Okay, okay, everyone breathe.

Silence. Forks on plates.

Father Patrick stares at Kelly over a slow sip of coffee. She shrinks.

COLLEEN
You've always been... sensitive.
(beat)
I mean that kindly.

KELLY
I'm not--

Kelly looks to Megan.

MEGAN
I'd say... empathetic? Not--

MAUREEN
Histrionic?

MEGAN
Right. We could use more sensitivity. Wouldn't you agree, Father Patrick?

Father Patrick slowly nods. No warmth.

SHANE
I'm sensitive too. Switched toothpaste. Can't drink ice cold beer anymore. Kevin, in London do they serve beer warm?

KELLY
Not warm. Just not iced to death. They want you to taste it. American beer's more about being light. Clean.
(beat)
Unobtrusive.

MEGAN
More palatable for consumption.

Kelly nods.

MEGAN (cont'd)
Pass the mashed potatoes?

MAUREEN
So, when will you be moving back to the States?

KELLY
Not planning to at the moment.

DECLAN
So you're going to stay there?

KELLY
I think so. I've kind of assimilated into the culture.

MAUREEN
Wow. I just couldn't imagine living anywhere else but the U.S.

RORY
Must be a lot of crime over there. All the immigrants. No guns.

Kelly inhales. Her hand trembles as she lifts her water glass. She sets it down carefully.

Sound drops slightly. Conversation continues, muffled.

The camera stays on Kelly as the room moves without her.

MEGAN (O.S.)
This is very good.

SHANE (O.S.)
Did I get the good seat this year?

COLLEEN (O.S.)
Anyone need salt or pepper?

SMASH MATCH CUT:

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME — DINING ROOM — LATER

Kelly hasn't moved. Dinner has become coffee and dessert. Pies, Cool Whip, plates. Ceramic scrapes loudly in the quiet.

COLLEEN
Kevin?

Colleen is holding a pie cutter. Kelly startles.

KELLY
Oh -- no, thank you.

COLLEEN
You sure? Suit yourself.

SHANE
I'll have whatever's easiest on the stomach.

COLLEEN
Pumpkin it is.

Father Patrick drinks his coffee black. Silent.

RORY
This turned out nice.

Murmurs of agreement.

Kelly stares at her empty plate. Sighs. Almost over.

COLLEEN
Oh, Kevin -- I watched your stand-up set online. I liked it.

KELLY
You did?

COLLEEN
I did. Why don't you pull it up on the big TV? Show everyone.

Kelly freezes.

KELLY
Mom... is that a good idea?

COLLEEN
Why wouldn't it be?

KELLY
My set isn't exactly for polite company.

COLLEEN
Oh, I didn't mind.

KELLY
It's not just the jokes.

COLLEEN
You mean the dress?

Kelly blinks.

KELLY
Uh--

Colleen pours coffee.

COLLEEN
Oh, don't worry. Everyone in the family knows.

Silence.

KELLY
Everyone... *knows*.

Kelly scans the faces. Megan is stunned. Everyone else already knows.

COLLEEN
Well, once you told Megan, I figured family was fine.

KELLY
(soft)
You told them. *Before dinner*.

A half-beat.

Shane snaps his fingers.

SHANE
That's what I forgot to tell you! I knew it was important. Right, Kevin -- congratulations on coming out.
(beat)
So... is this part of the act, or... your life now?

Kelly doesn't answer.

She stares into her coffee. Steam curls upward.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - *IMAGINED* - NIGHT

Kelly stands silent onstage. No laughter. No sound. *No audience*.

Stage lights die one by one -- KA-CHUNK. KA-CHUNK.

One spotlight remains. Kelly, exhausted and resigned.

KELLY
There's just nothing funny about that.

The spotlight goes dark with the loudest KA-CHUNK.

Darkness.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME — LIVING ROOM — DUSK

Kelly fumbles with cables beneath the TV as the family gathers behind her.

DECLAN
Need a hand?

KELLY
I -- I think--

The screen flickers. Black.

RORY
Here. Let me.

He steps forward, takes the remote. The TV comes alive.

INSERT: Kelly's stand-up set. Mid-joke. No sound.

DECLAN
(laughing)
Oh man. That's a gas.

Rory finds the volume. Sound clicks on. Kelly rises.

KELLY
I need to use the restroom.

Only Megan hears. Kelly is already heading upstairs.

INT. KELLY'S ROOM — DUSK

Kelly enters. Closes the door. She stands there, reclaiming a sliver of quiet.

Muffled laughter drifts up from downstairs.

She exhales, grabs her Switch, sits on the bed fully dressed. Shoes still on. Headphones in.

She plays. Only the faint click of buttons.

INSERT: ZELDA: BOTW - GERUDO DESERT

Link, still dressed in Gerudo women's clothing, crosses the desert. A sandstorm rolls in. Visibility collapses. The minimap disappears. Landmarks vanish. Direction dissolves. Lost. Link stops.

Kelly lowers the unpaused console, stares ahead.

She looks back. Link still stands in the storm.

Kelly exhales. She lifts the console again. Her thumb hovers. A faint tremor. Slowly... Link moves forward. Into the desert.

EXT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - TRANSITION - DUSK TO NIGHT

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Cable news murmurs from the TV. A Fox-like anchor.

Colleen and Rory watch TV from their recliners as Kelly descends.

COLLEEN
Hey. Welcome back.

RORY
If you want coffee, we moved the mugs above the coffee machine.

KELLY
Where is everyone?

COLLEEN
Declan and Maureen went back to their hotel. Father Patrick drove home. Shane's staying with Megan.

RORY
We figured the turkey knocked you out.

Kelly loads a K-Cup.

TUCKER-LIKE ANCHOR (TV)
Some doctors now say many children seeking puberty blockers may be responding to social pressure rather than medical need.
(beat)
And yet the treatments continue, even though there's still no long-term evidence they're safe.

Kelly shuts her eyes. Tries to ignore it.

Silence. The coffee machine hums.

COLLEEN
I just don't understand why anyone would do that to a kid.

Kelly tries to contain it -- but she can't.

KELLY
(rage)
Oh for the love of--!

Colleen turns. Rory keeps watching the TV.

COLLEEN
Kelly?

KELLY
He's lying. He *knows* he's lying.

COLLEEN
I still don’t think a child can make that decision.

KELLY
Kids need parental consent. The point is to delay puberty until they're old enough to decide, instead of making the irreversible decision for them.
(beat)
God, I wish I'd had that chance. If I'd known... I would have asked. Even back then.

Rory leans forward towards the TV, ignoring Kelly.

COLLEEN
Kelly, you're in your forties, why do you care about puberty blockers? It's a little late, isn't it?

Kelly's composure cracks.

KELLY
Mom, that's the *point*.
(near tears)
I had moments before when I thought I might be trans. But every time, I pushed them down because I thought -- my brow, my bones, my voice -- that I'd just be an ugly woman.
(beat)
And after forty years of my body producing testosterone... maybe I am. An ugly woman.
(beat)
I missed my chance to be pretty.
(beat)
I don’t want another kid to feel like I did.
(quiet)
To go through puberty... as a mutilation.

Colleen scoffs.

COLLEEN
Oh, come off it, Kelly. You weren't *mutilated*.

Kelly breaks.

KELLY
(shouting)
What the...!? Where do you get off telling me that?

KELLY
Do you think I'm doing this for kicks? I've always felt wrong, ugly -- This isn't politics. These are kids trapped in bodies they can't escape!

COLLEEN
Where do I get off? You're the one dressing like a clown, insisting something's wrong when there isn't -- and you're yelling at me? On Thanksgiving?

KELLY
You need to care about people who aren't you!

COLLEEN
Go to your room.

Silence.

KELLY
What?

COLLEEN
That's enough, Kevin. Go. To. Your. Room. How dare you yell at me in my own house!

Kelly closes her eyes. Jaw tight. She turns. Walks upstairs.

Rory watches. Says nothing.

COLLEEN
(calling after)
And yes, I'm calling you Kevin! That's the name you had as a child -- and you're acting like one!

INT. KELLY'S ROOM - NIGHT

Kelly is done. Door slammed. Suitcase open. The FLORAL DRESS goes in first -- rushed, crushed.

Makeup into a zip bag. Tossed in like evidence. Clothes from drawers. No folding. Nintendo Switch. Laptop. Backpack. Zip.

A gentle knock at the door.

Kelly looks upward. Grunts. She turns.

Rory opens the door without waiting. Reading glasses. A printed report in his hand, marked up.

RORY
Hey, uh... I was reading something.
(holds up report)
Says kids shouldn't be on blockers.

Kelly inhales slowly.

KELLY
Is that *the Cass Review*?

Rory checks.

RORY
Uh... yeah. Cass. Interim report.

KELLY
It's not science. It's politics wearing a lab coat.

RORY
You don't *know* that.

KELLY
That report hurt people I know. Real kids, Dad. Not headlines.

RORY
You don't know what they'll do to those kids.

KELLY
I know what *not* having them did to me!

Rory tightens. Kelly continues.

KELLY (cont'd)
As if trans kids don't have enough, now the NHS tells them: your feelings aren't real, something's wrong with your brain.

RORY
Kevin, you can't be reasoned with, sometimes.

KELLY
Dad, I have been *beyond* reasonable here.

RORY
But what if it really *is* mental illness? What if it's something that can be fixed? I'm not saying it is. I'm just saying... have you even *tried* therapy? Because you're starting to sound like a paranoid delusional.

Kelly stops and stares at him. Deep breath. Forced calm.

KELLY
Don't, Dad. Don't go there. I am *sick and tired* of you treating me like an unreliable narrator of my own life. At what point will you just *accept* that I know my own *mind?*

RORY
And what if you're wrong?!

Kelly looks at Rory. Her face falls. Sadness. Disappointment.

KELLY
Dad, I just need some time right now.

Rory backs off.

RORY
Alright. We'll be downstairs.

Rory leaves. Kelly sinks onto the bed.

KELLY
(to self)
Every time.
(beat)
If I knew something--I was wrong.
If I felt something--
(stops herself)
"Too much." "Overreacting."
(beat)
Jesus.
(quiet)
Why would I *ever* trust myself?

She picks up an oestrogen patch sachet.

KELLY (cont'd)
(soft, realizing)
But I did the math.
(beat, conviction)
I'm *right*.

INT. MARTIN'S NORWEGIAN FLAT - BEDROOM - NIGHT

Darkness. Quiet. Martin sleeps curled beside Greta. A phone rings and vibrates on the bedside table. The screen lights the room.

ON PHONE: KELLY CALLING. Her contact photo: the candid King of Stars shot, Kelly at her happiest.

An LED clock reads 1:15 A.M.

Martin groans, fumbles for the phone and taps DECLINE.

He nuzzles back into Greta.

The phone rings again.

Martin's eyes snap open. Exhausted annoyance.

INT. MARTIN'S NORWEGIAN FLAT — LIVING ROOM — NIGHT

Martin settles onto the couch under a thick blanket, drains his coffee.

MARTIN
I was hoping it wouldn’t go like that.
(beat)
I should’ve warned you better.

INTERCUT: KELLY'S ROOM / MARTIN'S LIVING ROOM:

Kelly lies on her bed, staring at the ceiling. Her breathing is still uneven.

KELLY
How could you have known? They were fine with you being trans. I don't know why it's different.

MARTIN
Kelly... they accepted me because I went from daughter to son.

Realization. Kelly covers her mouth.

MARTIN (cont'd)
Did you think they'd be fine with you becoming a daughter?

Kelly exhales. Shakes her head.

KELLY
Ah Shishkabob.

MARTIN
Yeah.
(beat)
For them... that’s not the same thing.
(beat)
Going one way--it reads like... moving up.
(beat)
The other--
(searching)
--they see you throwing something away.

Kelly sits up on the bed. She takes a moment to process. Then, redetermined:

KELLY
How do I reach them?

MARTIN
You can't.

KELLY
But I *have to*. If I just... explain it well enough. If I just say the right words then--

MARTIN
(sharp)
Kelly!

Kelly freezes.

MARTIN (cont'd)
You can't. Okay? You just can't.
(beat)
They don't think they're wrong.
(beat)
And they've never had to.

We stay with Kelly for a moment before moving on.

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY LIVING ROOM - DAWN

Dawn light edges in. Laika stirs on her bed. Biiiiig stretch. Shakes out, pads into the master bedroom.

Moments later, Rory emerges -- dressed, armed, bleary. He stops at the sight of Kelly alone at the kitchen table, laptop open.

RORY
Morning, Kevin. You're up early.

KELLY
Went to sleep early. Woke up early. Jet lag, I guess.

Rory nods.

RORY
I need to walk Laika... but when I get back, maybe you and I get breakfast? Just us. That place you like. Then maybe we go check out some Black Friday sales?

Kelly considers, numb. Doesn't look at him.

KELLY
Yeah.
(beat)
Sure.

Rory nods. He grabs Laika's harness. As Rory reaches for it, the BLACK PISTOL shifts slightly.

INT. RORY'S TRUCK - DAY

Silence. Kelly slumps in the passenger seat. Rory glances at her as he drives.

EXT. GUN SHOP - DAY

A modest white building beside the highway, between an antique shop and a tailor. It could be an insurance office or a small medical practice, apart from the patriotic signage and the rifles and handgun posters in the windows.

An oversized American flag adorns the roadside sign: "MINUTEMAN GUN SUPPLY." Even the parking barriers are painted red, white, and blue.

Rory pulls into the parking lot.

INT. RORY'S TRUCK - DAY

RORY
Say, Kevin, I just quickly want to check in on a gun I ordered. Mind if I leave you in the truck? Five minutes.

KELLY
Sure.

He exits. Heads inside. We stay with Kelly.

Waiting. Too long. Dead air.

Her eyes drift down to the cupholder. The one that holds Laika's kibble.

She freezes.

A SILVER REVOLVER in the cupholder. Loaded. Holstered. Not Rory’s usual BLACK PISTOL.

We stay on it. Long enough for the thought to form. Long enough to become undeniable.

Kelly doesn’t move. Doesn’t blink. Shallow breaths. We stay too long. Past comfort.

Her fingers twitch against her thigh.

Then stillness again.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - IMAGINED - NIGHT

Open in blackness.

A single spotlight KA-CHUNKS on. Kelly wears the same boy-mode clothes as in the truck. No makeup.

Silence except for the echo.

She grips the mic. Her hand trembles.

Kelly looks directly into camera.

KELLY
(4th wall break)
I know how this sounds. You probably think I'm exaggerating.
(beat)
It's important to me... that you believe me when I say...
(beat)
...*this happened*.
(beat)
This isn't something I made up.

INT. RORY'S TRUCK - DAY

Kelly is still staring at the gun. Unmoving.

Finally, Rory returns. Gets in. Starts the truck. Normal.

RORY
Right. Ready for breakfast? Chicken-fried steak again?

Kelly's voice trembles.

KELLY
Dad... you left me with a gun.

RORY
What?
(pause, looks down)
Oh, that? I knew you were in the truck.

KELLY
You left me *alone* with a *loaded gun*.

RORY
...What?

KELLY
Dad... you can't *do* that. I've struggled with depression my whole life. You know that. I'm not safe around guns.

RORY
Sorry. Thought you'd be fine.
Didn't think it'd be a big deal.

Kelly swallows.

KELLY
(shaken)
When we get home... we need to
talk about this.

RORY
Sure. We'll talk.
(beat)
Let's get pancakes.

Rory drives.

INT. KELLY'S ROOM - DAY

Kelly lies fully clothed in the fetal position -- just as she did at fifteen. Awake. Empty.

Her phone rings. She answers without looking.

KELLY
Kevin O'Connell speaking.

MEGAN (V.O.)
Hey, Kelly. How you holding up?

A pause before Kelly speaks.

KELLY
Aunt Megan?

MEGAN (V.O.)
Who'd you think it was, toots,
Rosie O'Donnell?

KELLY
(beat)
There's a surface resemblance.

MEGAN (V.O.)
You know, not to be funny, but
sometimes little kids ask me for
autographs.

KELLY
What do you tell them?

MEGAN (V.O.)
"There's no crying in baseball."

Kelly chuckles, surprising herself.

KELLY
Okay, *that's good*.

MEGAN (V.O.)
Let's get dinner. Mexican. That place that smooshes the avocados in front of you.

Kelly starts to re-enter the world.

KELLY
Uh, yeah. Sure. Just you and me?

MEGAN
What, you think I should invite Klansman Greg?

After a small delay... Kelly smiles.

INT. MEXICAN RESTAURANT - NIGHT

Guacamole smashed table-side. A good Mexican restaurant. Plates clink, low murmur.

Megan and Kelly share chips and guacamole.

MEGAN
Well, obviously I had to check in with you. Jeezus criminy, what a train wreck. And I owe you an apology.

KELLY
For what? You didn't do anything wrong.

MEGAN
That's just it. I didn't do anything. I should've said something. I was just... shocked. And outnumbered.

KELLY
I get it, though. I should have stood up for myself.

MEGAN
And that priest...

They both shiver in exaggerated horror.

KELLY
Like the Ghost of Thanksgiving Future.

MEGAN
First time I've heard grace start with the last rites.

KELLY
Maybe the turkey was Catholic.

MEGAN
Why not? We've got Holy Guacamole.

KELLY
And corpus crispies.

MEGAN
Ah yes, The Eucharist of champions.

They laugh together.

KELLY
You were right, Aunt Megan. I *needed* this.

MEGAN
I figured.
(beat)
Shane wanted to apologize. He thought he said something wrong.

KELLY
Shane? No. He's confused sometimes, but his heart's solid.

MEGAN
(softer)
Hey.

She slides the bowl of guac towards Kelly.

MEGAN (cont'd)
(beat)
Are you going to be okay?

Kelly shrugs. Picks at a chip. Doesn’t eat it.

KELLY
I don't know.

MEGAN
Do you have people in London? Friends who can help you through it?

Kelly smiles -- tired, but real.

(PRE-LAP): The sound of a crowd laughing.

INT. KING OF STARS - STAGE - NIGHT

Kelly's on stage again, full lights, full audience, floral dress. They're having a great time.

Kieran is in the wings.

KELLY
I got my degree from Central Texas University. God, I'm glad I didn't come out back then. Being openly trans in Texas is just a good way to get shot. And I don't want any holes drilled in me...
(comedy beat)
Except the one.
(laughter)
I hate gun violence. That's why I live in London. I *love* knife crime.
(laughter)
If you're used to gun violence? Knife crime is just... *quaint*.
(beat)
You're walking along late at night, a guy jumps out from the bushes with a ski mask and a powdered wig--
(camp, act-out)
"Stand and deliver your coin purse, good madam, lest I gut you, from tickle-gizzard to pleasure-pivot, with yon switching blade!"
(beat)
"Now now now, don't be cheese-pairing me, I want to see every last farthing and ha-penny!"
(big laughter)
That's what I love. A good old fashioned artisanal mugging.

Laughter.

Familiar faces: Nigel, Ellie, Samantha, even the Samaritans-card audience member. All enjoying themselves.

KELLY (cont'd)
The gun culture in America has my dad refusing to go anywhere without his concealed-carry pistol. Because you never know where the next ninja attack is com--

She stops suddenly.

Frozen.

Breath audible. Laughter decays naturally. Room tone grows. A glass clinks somewhere.

FLASH CUTS:

- Rory, again and again, with the BLACK PISTOL.

- Then we cut to the scene in the truck. *SILVER REVOLVER*.

RORY (V.O.)
(memory)
I'd stay away from revolvers... Too simple. Nothing between the thought and the trigger.

BACK TO STAGE:

Kelly stands motionless. Audience murmurs.

KELLY
(not into mic)
He never carries a revolver.

A laugh--late, uncertain--dies quickly.

Kieran steps forward -- stops.

Kelly breathes. The room stills.

KELLY (cont'd)
Sorry.
(beat)
That joke just got a lot less funny.
(beat)
Anyway--
(gear shift)
--now I'm back in England. Land of the crumpet.
(beat)
You know, before I moved to England, I didn't realize crumpets... were *real*.
(beat)
First time I bought some, the guy said “two quid.” So naturally I asked: how many pounds in a quid?

Beat. Laughter.

KELLY (cont'd)
(angry)
Guy told me it was TEN POUNDS to the QUID! Ugh.

More laughter.

KELLY (cont'd)
Naturally, I never went back there. Started shopping at Aldi. There, crumpets are only seven pounds to the quid.

Huge Laughter.

KELLY (cont'd)
Anyway, I've been Kelly O'Connell, I hope you had as much fun coming out tonight as I have.

Applause. Kelly takes a curtsey.

INT. KING OF STARS - UPSTAIRS BAR - NIGHT

The show is over. Kelly sits at the bar, makeup off, dress hidden under travel clothes. She sits at the bar. Kieran comes over and sits on the barstool next to her.

KIERAN
So, what was all that about?

KELLY
(quiet, unsettled)
He left me with a revolver. He never carries one. I thought he was careless... he probably was careless... but what if he--

She can't complete the thought.

KELLY (cont'd)
Did my dad really leave it out, hoping I'd become a taste tester at Smith & Wesson?

Neither Kelly or Kieran speak for a moment. Finally:

KIERAN
I hear their flavours are mind-blowing.

Kelly breaks, laughing.

KELLY
Jesus, Kieran!

KIERAN
Little worried that might be too much.

KELLY
Nah.
(beat)
Perfect.
(beat)
You gotta laugh, right?

Kelly takes a long sigh.

KELLY (cont'd)
I mean, it was bad enough that he left me unattended with a gun. I guess I'll never know if he did it on purpose.

Ash, the gender-non conforming patron approaches Kelly and Kieran. Kieran spots them.

KIERAN
Oh, Kelly, I hope you wouldn't mind. This is Ash, they wanted to ask you a couple of questions.

Kelly nods, offers as handshake.

KELLY
Hello. Kelly O'Connell.

ASH
Yes, I just saw your act.

KELLY
Right. Of course you did.

Ash looks around.

ASH
Keiran said you'd be willing to talk a bit after the act? Which was great, by the way.

KELLY
Really? You thought it was funny?

ASH
Yeah. Except the sad parts. Bit of a tonal shift. Got funny again at the end.
(beat)
I also wanted to say-- thank you. For sharing the story.

KELLY
You're welcome. I used to think I did stand-up as an alternative to therapy. Now I think I do it because it's the one place I can tell my story without getting interrupted or shut down.

Kieran, reading the room, leaves Kelly and Ash alone.

ASH
You said people could ask questions...
(beat)
I think I might be trans. Or... something. I don't know.

Kelly smiles.

KELLY
Well I'll be. An *egg*.

ASH
Yeah. (pause) Wait, a what?

The camera begins to drift away from the bar.

KELLY (O.S.)
Don't worry about it. Point is, you're in control of your own life. Whatever you decide to do. Whoever you decide to be.

Kieran laughs with patrons. Sam chats up a guy. Ellie holds hands with her girlfriend. A man flirts with an oblivious Nigel.

Queer and ally patrons in easy conversation. A cracked glass. A progress-pride pin catching light. Glasses clink. Stories flow.

Not perfect. Real. Warm.

KELLY (O.S.) (cont'd)
Who you are? How you feel?
(beat)
You're not wrong. No matter what anyone tells you.
(beat)
And you've got friends here, if you want them. Found family. Look around. Ash. These are your people.

ASH (O.S.)
I was thinking about coming out to my parents this Christmas.
(beat)
While I'm home from uni.

WHIP-PAN back to Kelly.

Her face: absolute alarm.

KELLY
Oh, *fuck* no.

CUT TO BLACK:

OVER CREDITS

We hear a series of voicemail calls from Colleen.

SFX: Beep

COLLEEN (V.O.)
Hey, sweetie. How's the new year going? Everything okay?
(MORE)

COLLEEN (V.O.) (cont'd)
(pause)
Haven't heard from you in a while. Just wanted to make sure you're alright. A mother worries, you know. Talk to you later.
(beat)
I love you.

SFX: Beep

COLLEEN (V.O.) (cont'd)
Hey, Kelly. I saw the new stand-up set you put on YouTube. It's even better than the last one. Your birthday's coming up. Wondering if you want us to get you anything.
(beat)
Call me when you get this, okay?
(soft)
Talk to you later.
(beat)
I love you.

SFX: Beep

COLLEEN (V.O.) (cont'd)
Kelly. Can you call me? Just to let me know you're alright?
(beat)
Please?
(beat)
I don't know why you're mad at us.
(beat)
Okay.
(beat)
Okay.
(beat)
We'll be here when you're ready to talk.
(long beat)
I love you.

Silence.

POST CREDITS

INT. O'CONNELL FAMILY HOME - KITCHEN - DAY

A food processor BUZZES past peanut butter, beef broth and whipped cream.

Shane pours the mixture into a wide mug, crowns it with whipped cream.

When he finishes, he places a dog biscuit in the whipped cream as a garnish.

SHANE
One pup-puchino, coming up.

He sets it before a patiently waiting Laika. Good girl. She digs in.

Shane scratches behind Laika's ears.

Something orange peeks out from beneath her collar.

He gently tugs it free.

A faded Monopoly $500 bill.

Tail wagging, tongue licking, Laika *adores* Shane.

THE END